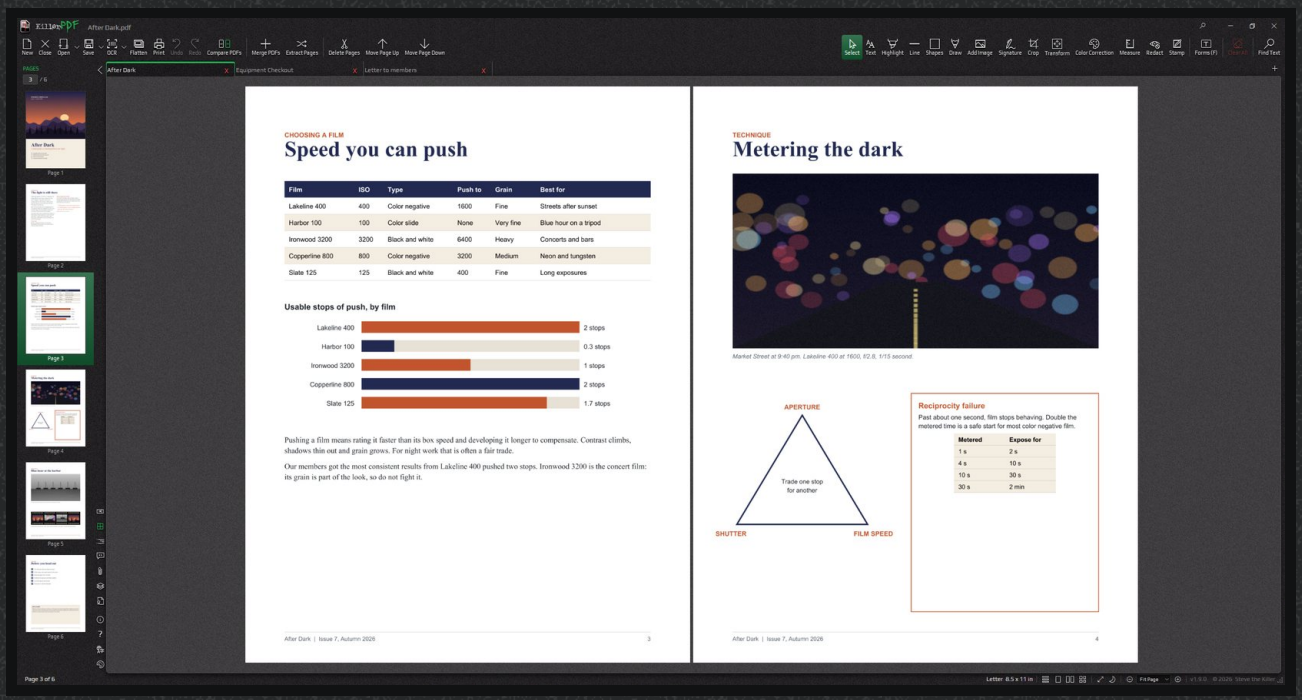
KillerPDF

Feature guide

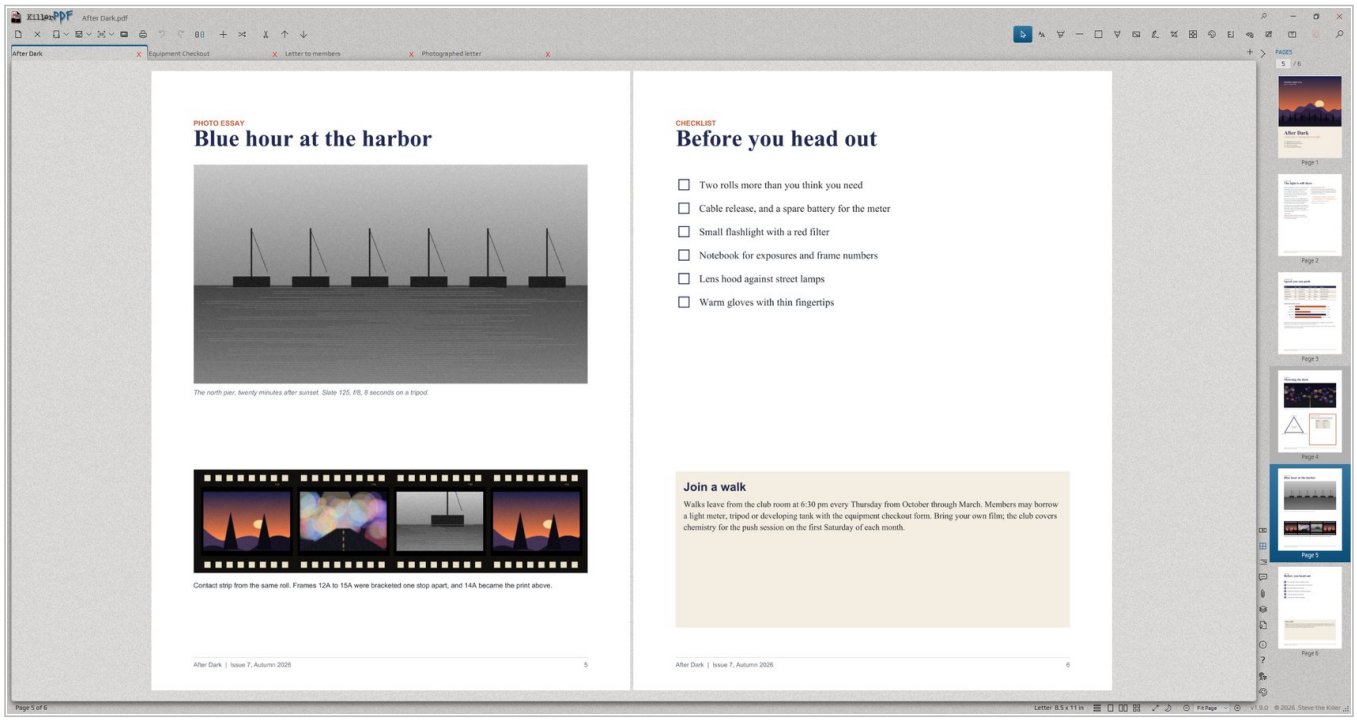
VERSION 1.9



A free, open source PDF editor for Windows, with its own PDF engine.

Welcome to KillerPDF

KillerPDF is a free PDF viewer and editor for Windows. You can read, annotate, organize, compare, fill, sign, OCR and batch process PDFs on your own computer, with no account.



KillerPDF maximized in the Light theme with the Blue accent, four tabs open and the sidebar on the right.

What it is

KillerPDF is a desktop app for Windows, released under the GPL-3.0 license and part of the Killer Tools family. Version 1.9, named Overkill, runs on KillerPDF's own PDF engine, which handles rendering, text extraction, search, editing, printing and export. There is no account to create, and the project describes itself as local-only with no telemetry. It is for anyone who works with PDFs on Windows and prefers to keep the files on their own machine.

At a glance

- 13 themes and 8 accent colors
- 20 interface languages
- 4 view modes plus Book layout
- 6 sidebar panels
- 32 buttons on the default toolbar
- App size from 70 to 250 percent

What is new in 1.9

Version 1.9 replaces the engine under the app and adds a lot on top of it. These are the biggest changes.

Engine

- KillerPDF's own engine replaces PDFium, Docnet.Core and PdfPig for rendering, text, search, selection, editing, printing and export.
- Rendering runs off the UI thread, with viewport priority, cancellation and zoom refinement.
- Damaged PDFs open and save more reliably, including encrypted documents and forms.

Editing and documents

- Edit paragraphs, and use Find and Replace on supported source text.
- Convert Scan to Text swaps scanned words for searchable text.
- Export to Word, Excel, PowerPoint, HTML, Markdown, text and JSON.
- Form tools, page tools, production tools and Convert DOCX or XLSX directly to PDF.

Security

- Permanent redaction by area, text search or sensitive-data pattern, with verification.
- Save AES-256 encrypted copies with passwords, permissions or certificate recipients.
- Inspect signers and certificate chains, with RFC 3161 timestamps.
- Updates install only after a checksum and publisher signature check.

Workspace and automation

- Search Tools (Ctrl+K), customizable shortcuts and one-letter tool keys.
- Six sidebar panels, four sidebar positions, Windows 11 snap layouts and a Film Grain switch.
- Guided tasks, macros, watched folders and Data merge for CSV, JSON or XLSX.
- Command-line workflows with flexible splitting, single-input merging and batch rendering.

What is inside

I. THE WORKSPACE 05
- A tour of the main window 06
- View modes, zoom and fit 07
- The sidebar 08
- Tabs and split panes 09
- Themes 10
- All thirteen themes 11
- Accents, grain and app size 12
- Eight accents on Light and Dark 13
- The toolbar and Search Tools 14
- Finding things and moving around 15
- Where settings live 16

II. MARKUP AND REVIEW 17
- How markup works 18
- Select, group and arrange 19
- Text and typewriter 20
- Highlight, underline and strikethrough 21
- Draw, lines and shapes 22
- Add Image and the image library 23
- Measure 24
- Comments 25
- Stamp Pages 26

III. PAGES AND DOCUMENTS 27
- The Pages panel 28
- Merge, extract, split and reorder 29
- Compare two PDFs 30
- Crop 31
- Transform and perspective 32
- Color correction 33
- Scanning and scan cleanup 34
- OCR 35
- Reduce file size 36
- Export and conversion 37
- Bookmarks and document structure 38
- Printing and production layouts 39

IV. FORMS AND SIGNATURES 40
- Filling forms 41
- Creating form fields 42
- Form data and Data Merge 43
- Visual signatures and initials 44
- Digital signatures 45
- Checking signatures 46

V. SECURITY 47
- Redaction: marking and applying 48
- Redaction: search, sanitize, verify 49
- Protect with passwords and certificates 50
- Preflight and accessibility reports 51

VI. AUTOMATION 52
- Macros and Guided tasks 53
- Watched folders and batch runs 54
- The command line 55
- Command reference, part 1 56
- Command reference, part 2 57
- Command reference, part 3 58

VII. THE ENGINE 59
- The KillerPDF.Engine 60
- Standards and security 61
- Proof: corpus and tests 62
- Components and fonts 63

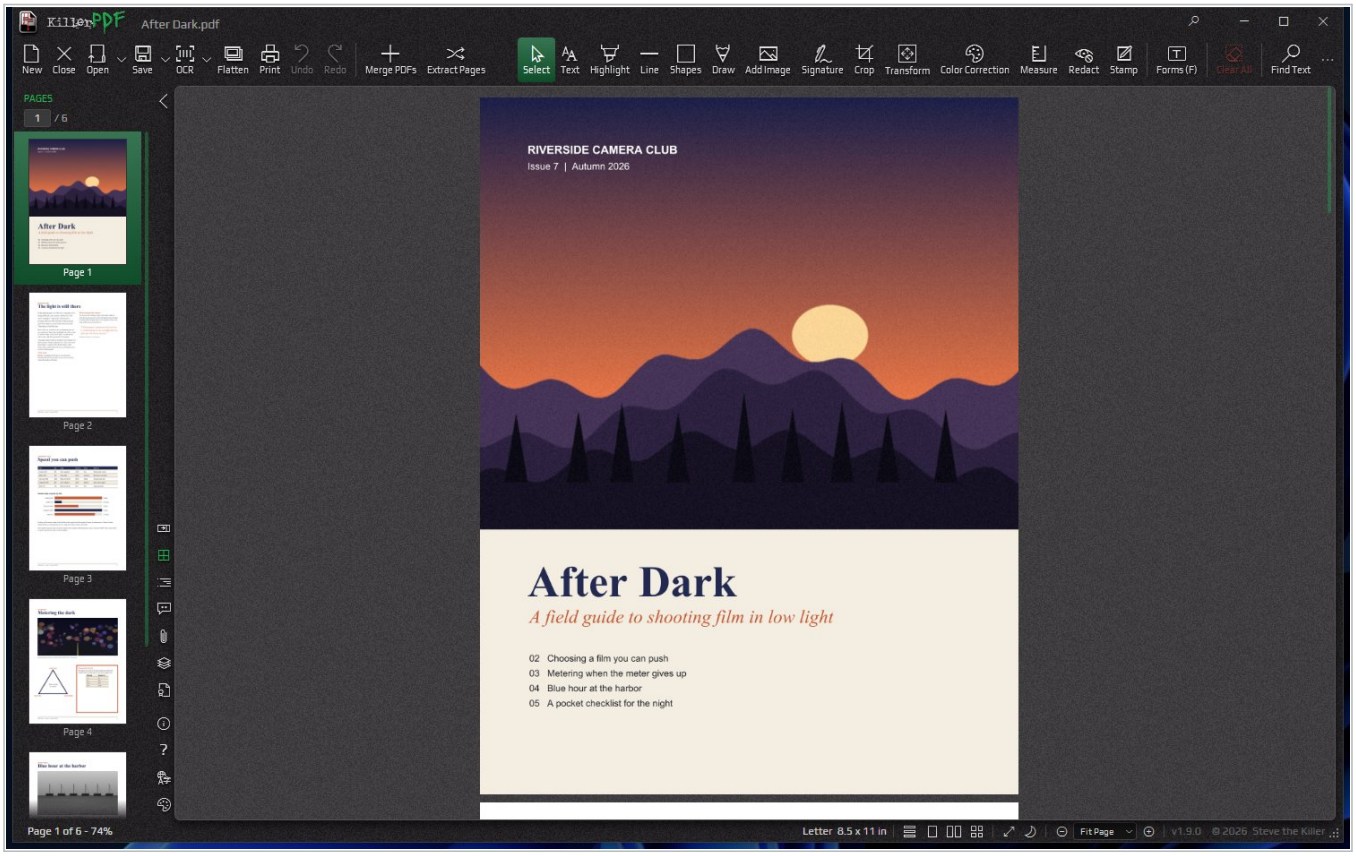
VIII. REFERENCE 64
- Keyboard shortcuts: file, tools and editing 65
- Keyboard shortcuts: view and navigation 66
- Keyboard shortcuts: document tools 67
- Interface languages 68
- Install, update and requirements 69
- KillerMCP and KillerNotes 70

The workspace

- Views, panels, tabs and split panes
- Thirteen themes and eight accents
- Toolbar, search and navigation

A tour of the main window

The window has the same few regions in every theme. Knowing where each one lives makes the rest of this guide easier to follow.



The standard window in the Dark theme.

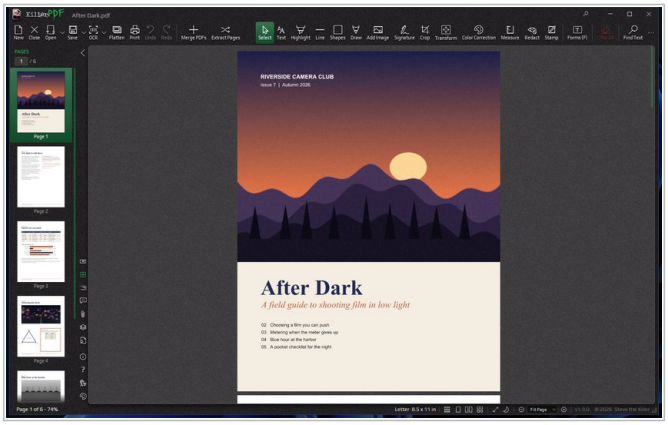
The regions

Region	What is there
Title bar	Window controls and Search Tools, the magnifier left of Minimize. Optional Previous and Next page buttons can be turned on here.
Toolbar	The tool buttons. Right-click it to customize.
Tab strip	One tab per open document, one strip per pane.
Sidebar rail	Collapse, Split pane, the six panel buttons, Document info, Keyboard shortcuts, Language and Theme.
Sidebar panel	Pages, Outline, Comments and measurements, Attachments, Layers or Signatures.
Document area	The pages you are reading or editing.
Footer	Status line, page size, zoom, view modes, Invert colors, Full screen and the version label.

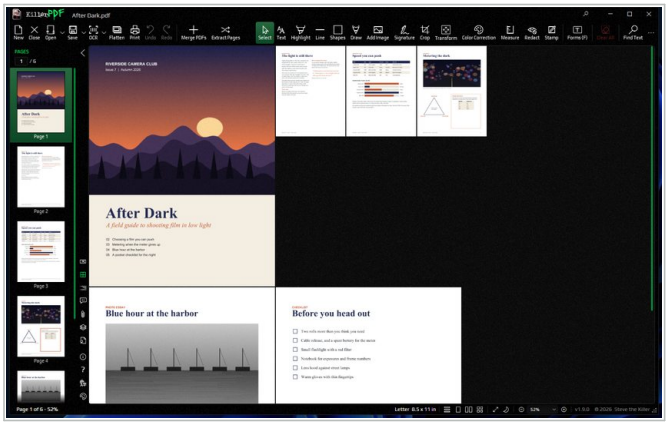
Tip. The window opens at 1000 by 700 pixels and can shrink to 620 by 480. Click the version label in the footer, or press F12, to open the About card.

View modes, zoom and fit

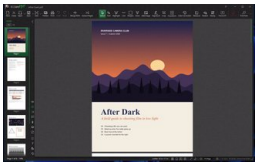
KillerPDF shows a document four ways, plus a Book layout for facing pages. Switch from the footer buttons or with the function keys.



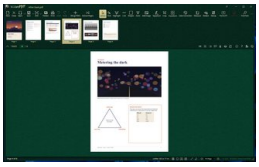
Continuous view, the default for a document with no saved state.



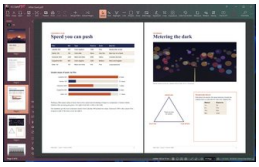
Grid view shows thumbnails of the whole document.



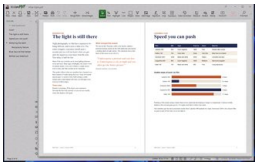
Continuous (F5)



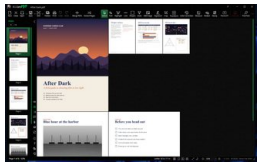
Single Page (F6)



Two Page (F7)



Book layout (B)



Grid (F8)

The five ways to view

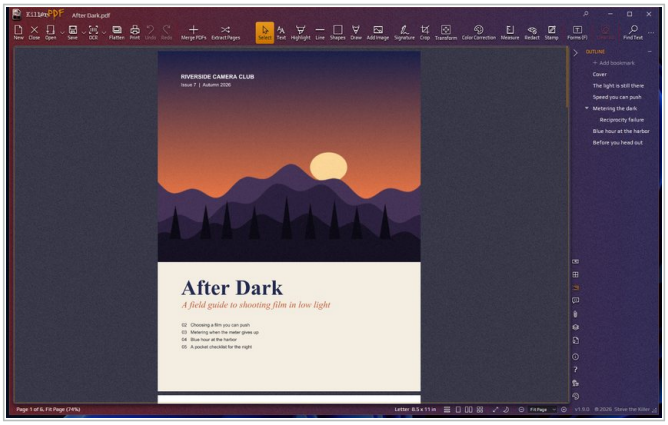
View	Key	Notes
Continuous	F5	Pages scroll in one column.
Single Page	F6	One page at a time.
Two Page	F7	Two pages side by side.
Book layout	B	Works in Two Page. The cover sits alone in its row.
Grid	F8	Zoom changes the number of columns.

Zoom and fit

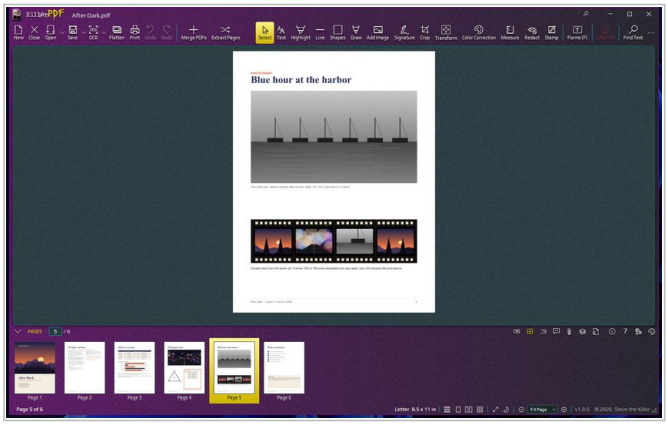
- The footer zoom box offers Fit Page, Fit Width, 50, 75, 100, 125, 150 and 200 percent.
- Ctrl+0 resets to 100 percent. Ctrl+1 is Actual size, Ctrl+2 Fit width, Ctrl+3 Fit page.
- In Continuous, Single Page and Two Page, Ctrl+scroll zooms around the pointer. In Grid it changes the number of columns. Pinch works on touch and precision touchpads.
- Each document remembers its view, zoom, page and scroll position, for your 40 most recent documents.

The sidebar

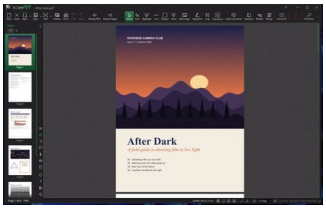
The sidebar is a rail of icon buttons and one panel at a time. It can sit on any of the four sides of the window.



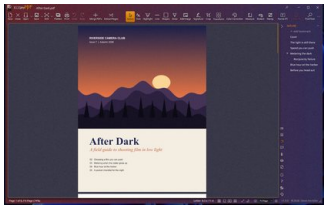
The sidebar on the right.



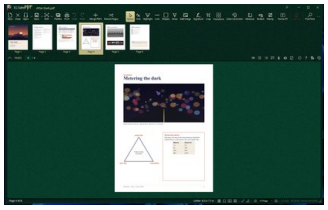
The sidebar along the bottom.



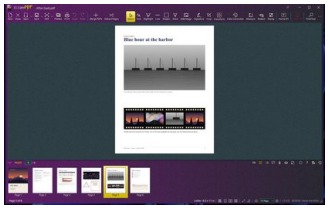
Left (the default)



Right



Top



Bottom

The six panels

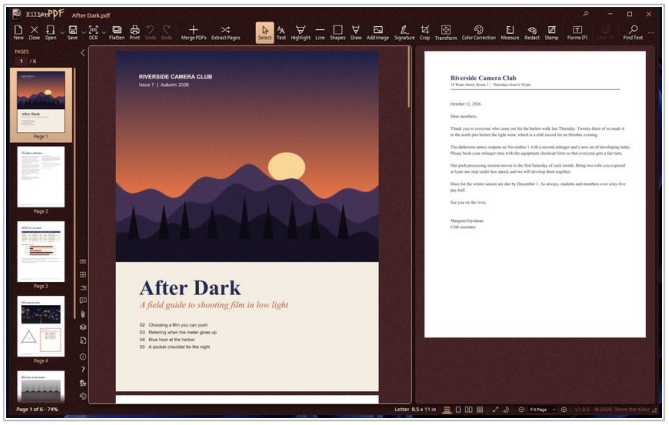
Panel	Key
Pages	Alt+1
Outline	Alt+2
Comments and measurements	Alt+3
Attachments	Alt+4
Layers	Alt+5
Signatures	Alt+6

Position and behavior

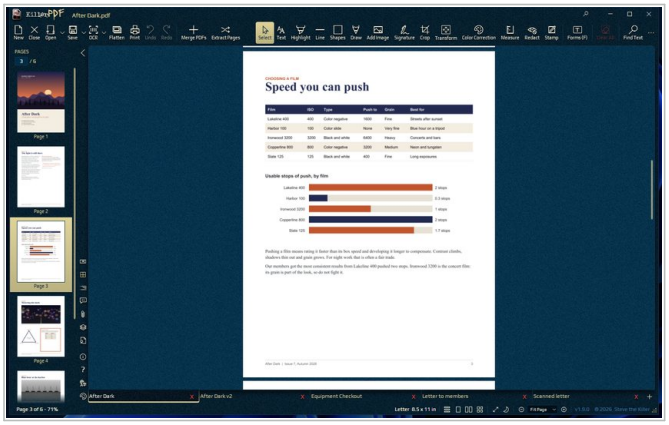
- Press F9 to show or hide the sidebar.
- Closing or opening the panel with its arrow or F9 is remembered next time you start KillerPDF.
- Press Shift+F9 to move it to the next side: Left, Right, Top, then Bottom.
- The rail also offers Move icons to the other side, and it remembers the order of its buttons.
- Panel buttons stay disabled until a document is open. Outline also stays disabled for a read-only document without bookmarks.

Tabs and split panes

Every document opens in a tab. Press F10 and a second pane lets you read two documents side by side.



Two documents side by side with F10.



The tab strip placed along the bottom.

Tabs

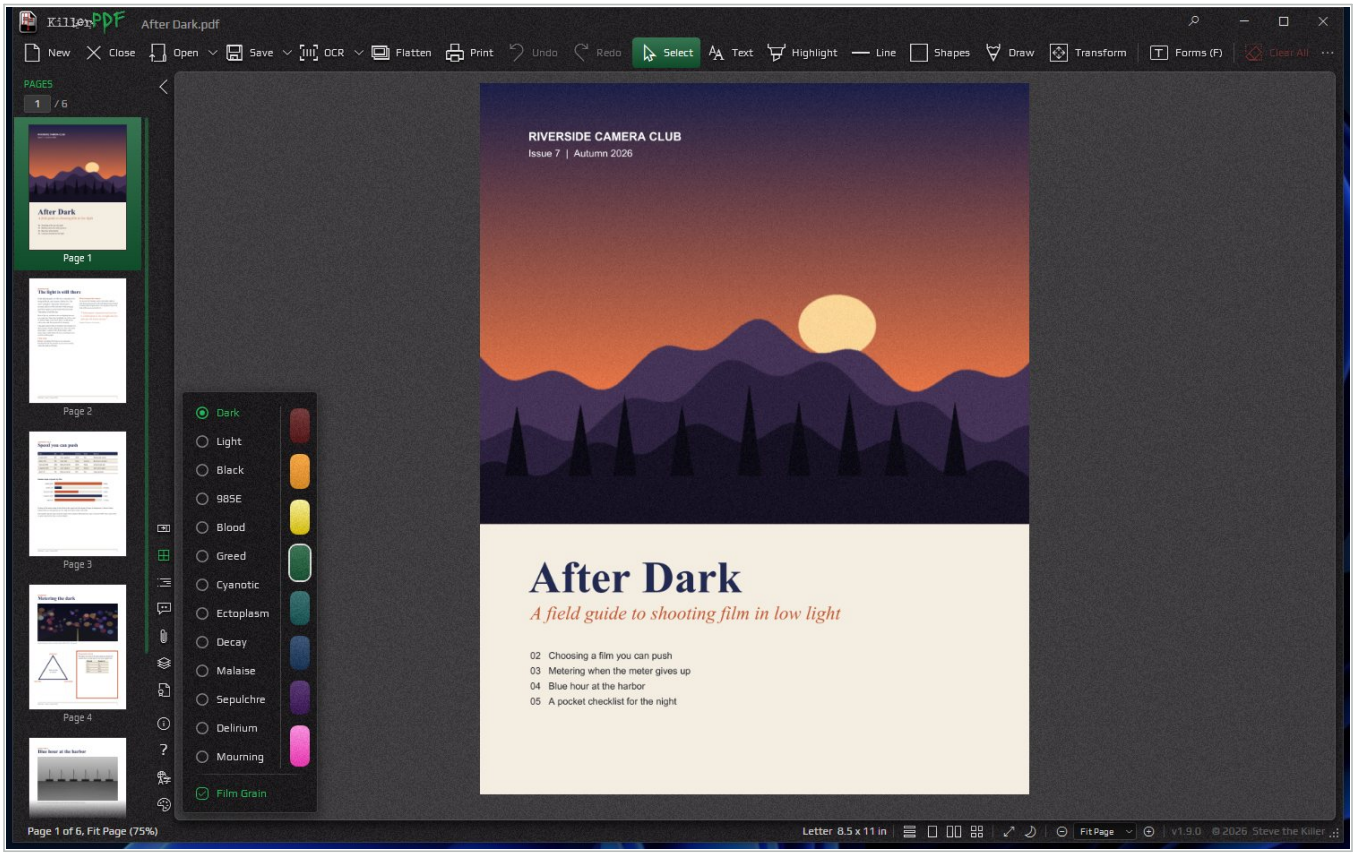
- Alt+Shift+Up puts the strip on top. Alt+Shift+Down puts it on the bottom.
- Tabs that do not fit move into an overflow chevron, All open tabs.
- Drag a tab to reorder it. Drag it over the other pane to move it there without reloading.
- Drag a tab out past the window edge, or press Ctrl+Shift+N, to move it to a new window.
- Ctrl+Tab and Ctrl+Shift+Tab step through tabs.

Split panes

- Each pane keeps its own tabs, page, zoom, view mode, scroll position, tool, annotations, undo stack and night mode.
- The toolbar, sidebar, footer and status line are shared. The focused pane receives every command.
- A pane is at least 320 pixels wide. The split and its tabs come back at next launch.

Themes

KillerPDF has 13 themes. Open the Theme button on the sidebar rail to pick one. The change cross-fades, and no restart is needed.



The theme menu with the theme list, accent swatches and Film Grain.

The thirteen themes

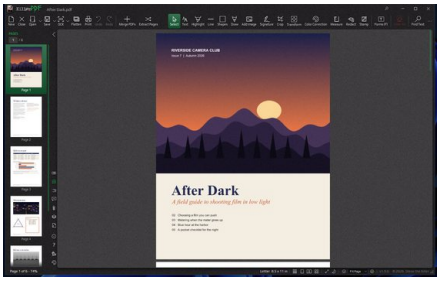
In menu order: Dark, Light, Black, 98SE, Blood, Greed, Cyanotic, Ectoplasm, Decay, Malaise, Sepulchre, Delirium and Mourning. A first run starts in Dark with the Green accent. Ectoplasm, Decay, Sepulchre, Delirium and Malaise use gradients for the window background and title bar.

What makes 98SE different

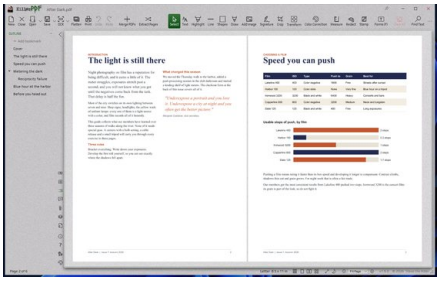
- It recreates classic beveled Windows chrome, with square corners.
- The interface font is Microsoft Sans Serif.
- It keeps a gray document workspace and uses light window chrome.
- It has no film grain.

All thirteen themes

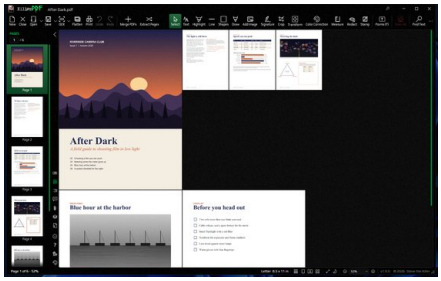
Every theme recolors the whole window: title bar, toolbar, rail, tabs, panels and footer. Each shot below also shows a different part of the workspace.



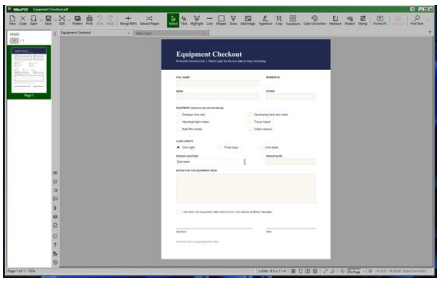
Dark: Continuous view, Pages panel



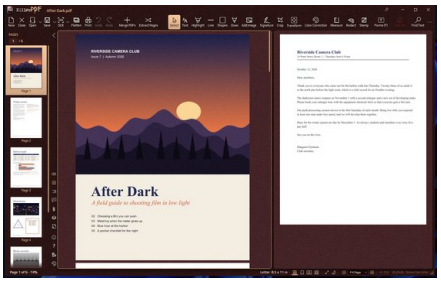
Light: Book layout, Outline panel



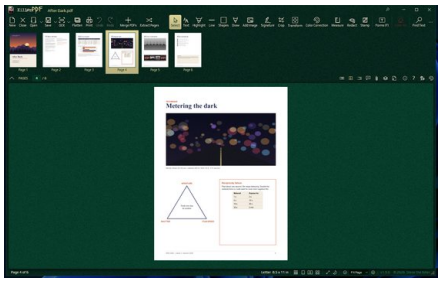
Black: Grid view



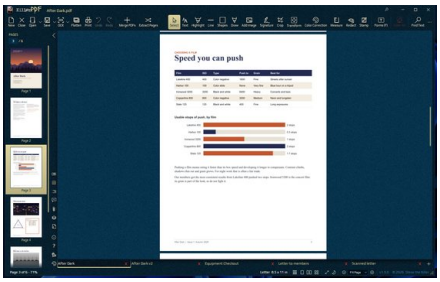
98SE: the checkout form



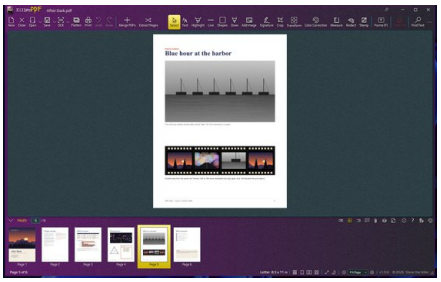
Blood: split pane



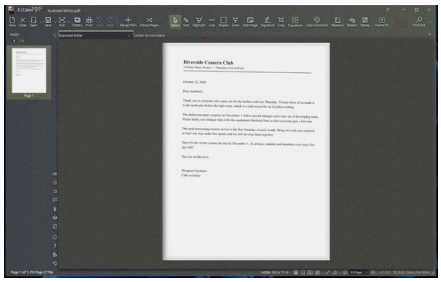
Greed: sidebar on top



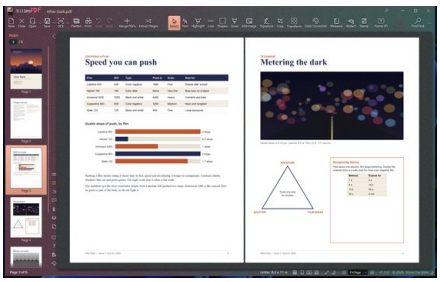
Cyanotic: tabs on the bottom



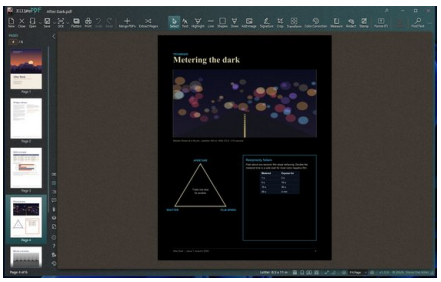
Ectoplasm: sidebar on the bottom



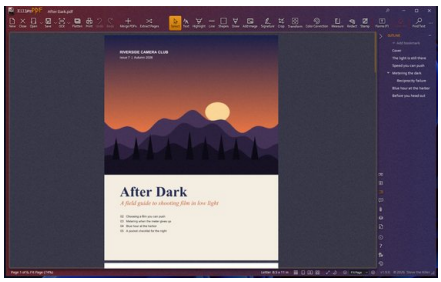
Decay: a scanned letter



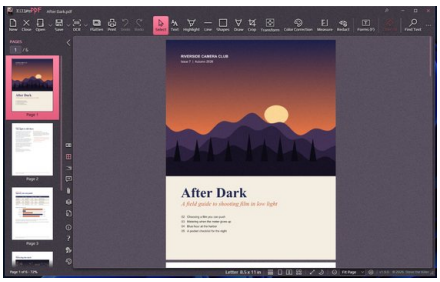
Malaise: Two Page view



Sepulchre: night mode



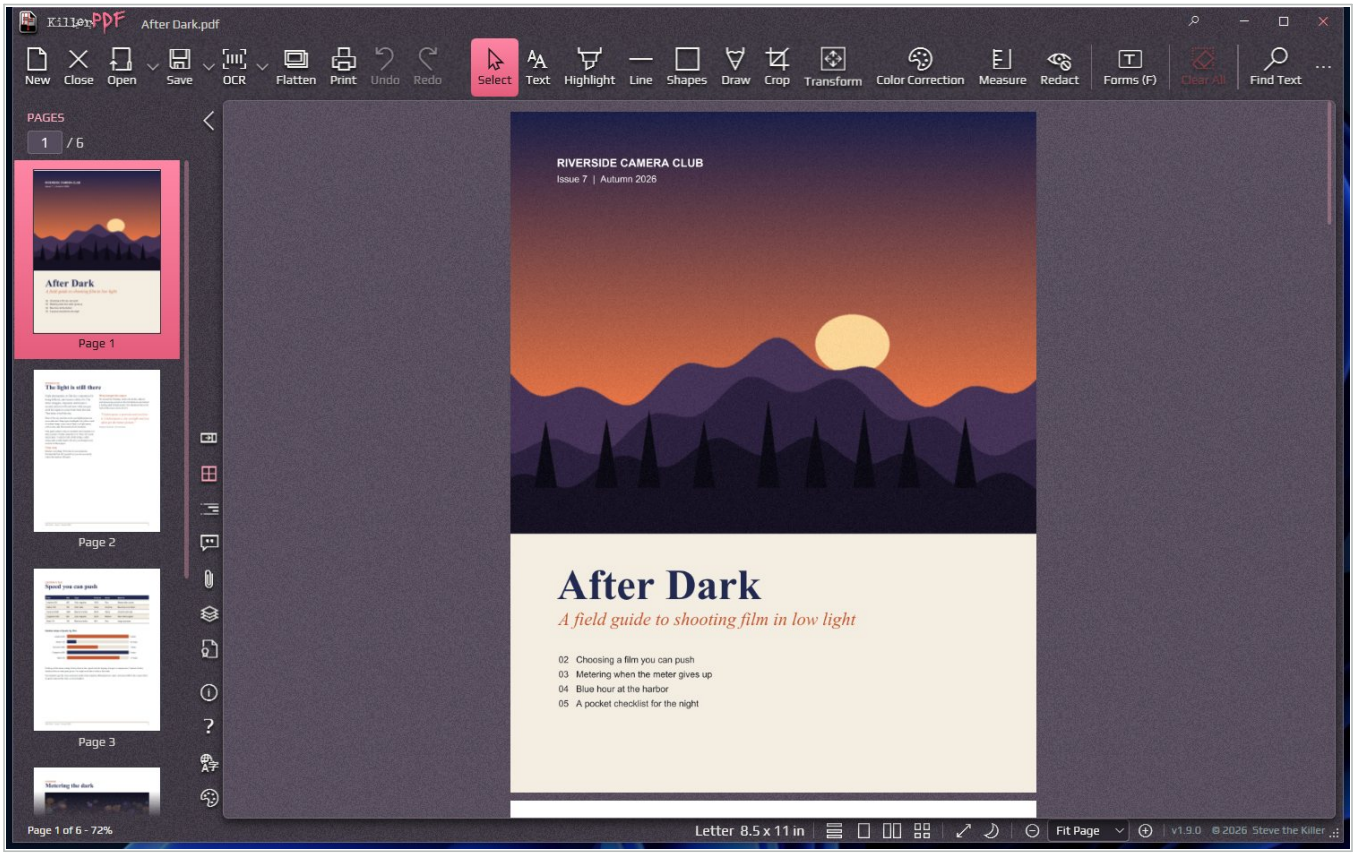
Delirium: sidebar on the right



Mourning: a larger app size

Accents, grain and app size

Four themes take an accent color. Film Grain, app size and Windows contrast themes round out how the app looks.



The interface at a larger app size.

Accents and Film Grain

- Eight accents: Red, Orange, Yellow, Green, Teal, Blue, Purple and Magenta.
- Only Dark, Light, Black and 98SE take accents, and each remembers its own.
- Pick an accent from the swatch strip beside the theme list. Arrow keys move between swatches.
- Film Grain is a switch under the theme list, on by default. Press Alt+Shift+G to toggle it.

Change the app size

1. Press Ctrl+Shift++ to make the interface larger.
2. Press Ctrl+Shift+- to make it smaller.
3. Press Ctrl+Shift+0 to reset to 100 percent.
4. Or turn the mouse wheel over the logo. The range is 70 to 250 percent.

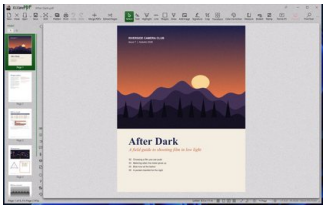
Windows contrast themes

When Windows contrast colors are on, KillerPDF uses the system colors without grain or shadows. It follows the Windows setting live. The Black theme is an ordinary theme, not a contrast mode.

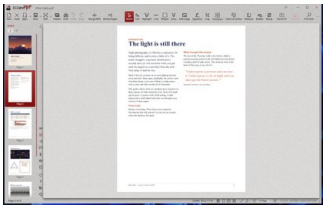
Eight accents on Light and Dark

Dark, Light, Black and 98SE take an accent, and each remembers its own. The accent colors the selected tool, the checked items and the highlights around the window.

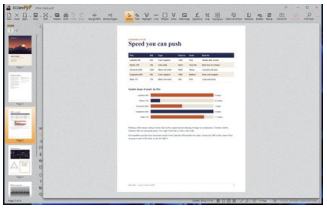
Light



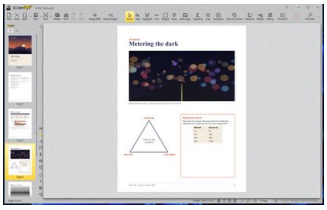
Green



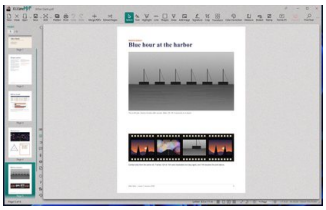
Red



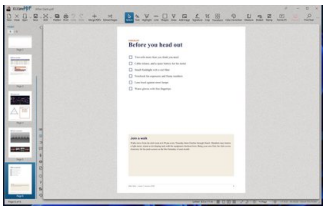
Orange



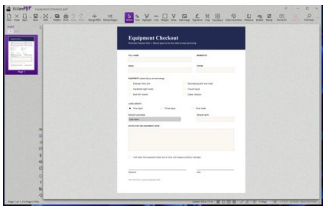
Yellow



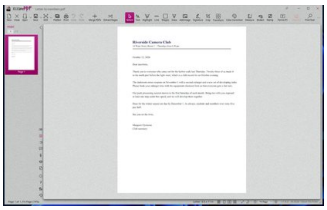
Teal



Blue

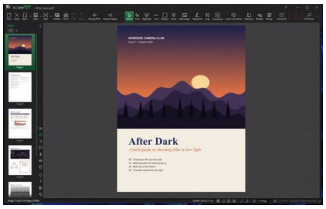


Purple

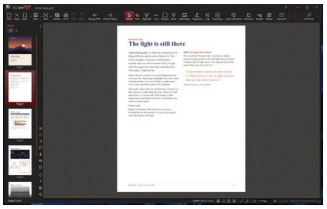


Magenta

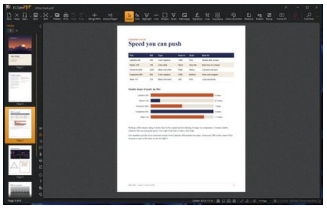
Dark



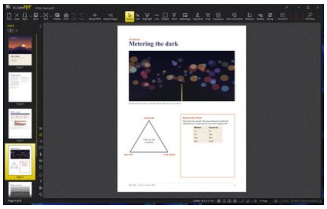
Green



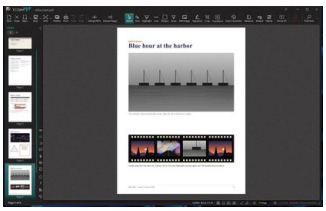
Red



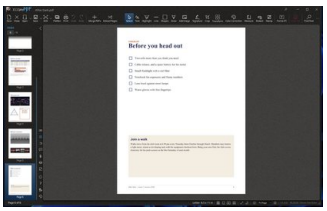
Orange



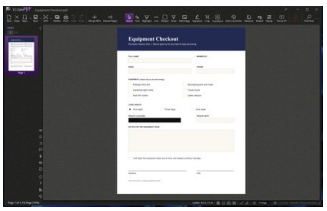
Yellow



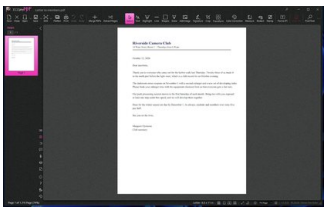
Teal



Blue



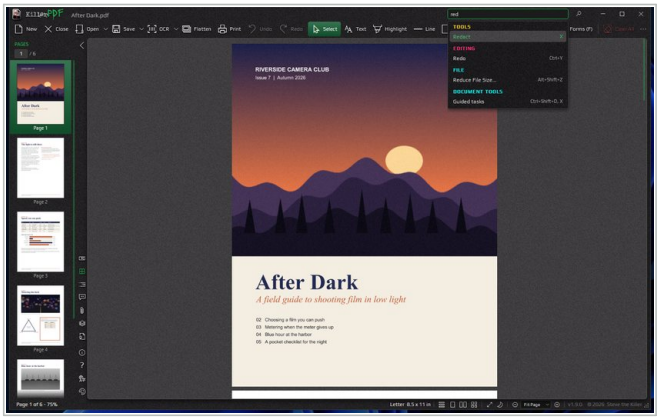
Purple



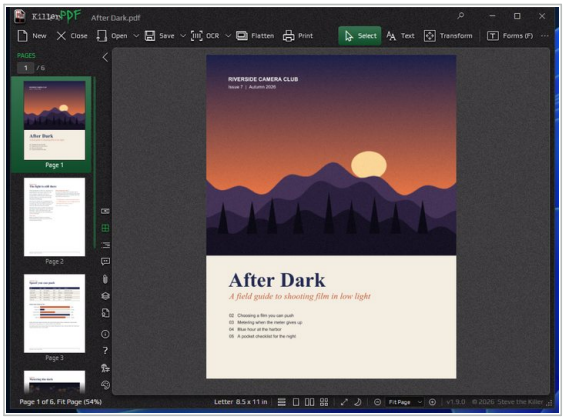
Magenta

The toolbar and Search Tools

The default toolbar has 32 buttons. You can restyle it, reorder it, or skip it and search for any command.



Search Tools listing matching commands.



A narrow window with tools moved into the More menu.



Small icons, large icons, text beside, text under, text only, and large icons with text under

Use Search Tools

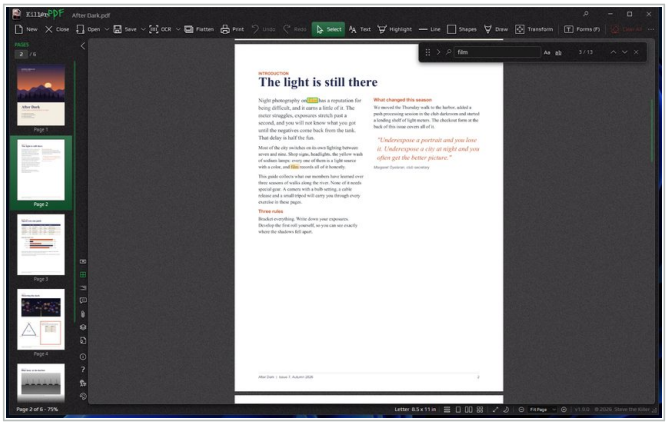
1. Press Ctrl+K, or click the magnifier left of Minimize.
2. Start typing a tool or command name.
3. Press Enter or click a result to run it.

Toolbar behavior

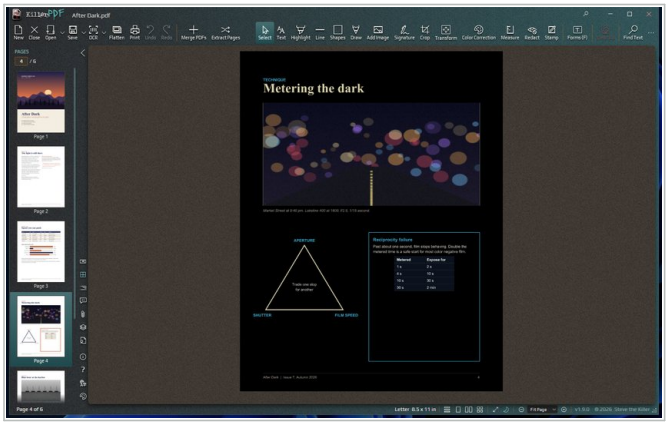
- Two settings combine: icon size, Small (Ctrl+Shift+1) or Large (Ctrl+Shift+2), and where the text goes, none (Ctrl+Shift+3), beside the icons (4), under them (5) or text only (6).
- Right-click the toolbar and choose Customize toolbar to reorder buttons, choose the side and move buttons to More.
- As the window narrows, groups move into the More chevron. Select and the active tool stay on the bar.
- Alt+M hides the toolbar.

Finding things and moving around

Search, history, night mode and full screen each have a single key. The shortcuts card lists everything.



Find Text with matches highlighted.



Invert document colors on the photo page.

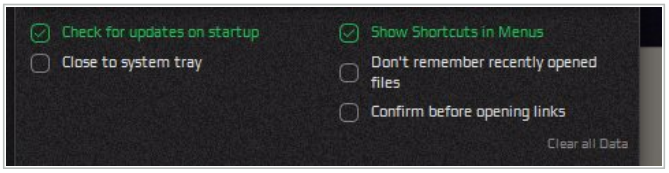
Quick reference

Feature	Key	Notes
Back and forward	Alt+Left, Alt+Right	Jump history. The mouse back and forward buttons work too.
Find Text	Ctrl+F	A bar you can drag. Alt+C matches case, Alt+W whole words.
Find and Replace	Ctrl+H	Enter replaces one. Ctrl+Alt+Enter replaces all.
Night mode	N	Display only. Shift+N inverts images too.
Full screen	F11	Hides all chrome. F11 or Esc leaves.
Page buttons	Alt+Shift+N	Optional Previous and Next in the title bar.
Shortcuts card	F1	A list and a keyboard map.

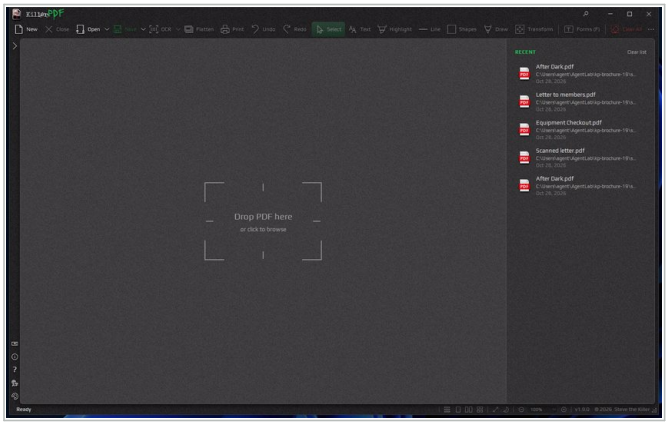
Tip. Night mode affects only the focused pane, so a split can show one document inverted beside a normal one.

Where settings live

There is no Settings panel in 1.9. Each setting lives next to the thing it changes, and the rest are on the About card.



The settings on the About card (F12).



The start screen with the recent files list.

Where to find them

Setting	Where
Theme, accent, Film Grain	Rail, Theme button
Language	Rail, Language button
View, zoom, night mode	Footer
Toolbar style and layout	Toolbar right-click menu
Sidebar side, tab placement	Sidebar and tab menus
Update check, Close to system tray, Show Shortcuts in Menus, Don't remember recently opened files, Confirm before opening links, Clear all Data	About card (F12)

Remembering and recovery

- Recent files: the 10 most recent appear on the start screen.
- Open tabs, window size and the split restore at next launch. Ticking Close my open tabs in the quit prompt turns tab restore off. Don't remember recently opened files only stops the recent files list.
- If the display fails, unsaved documents are saved aside and the app restarts in software rendering.

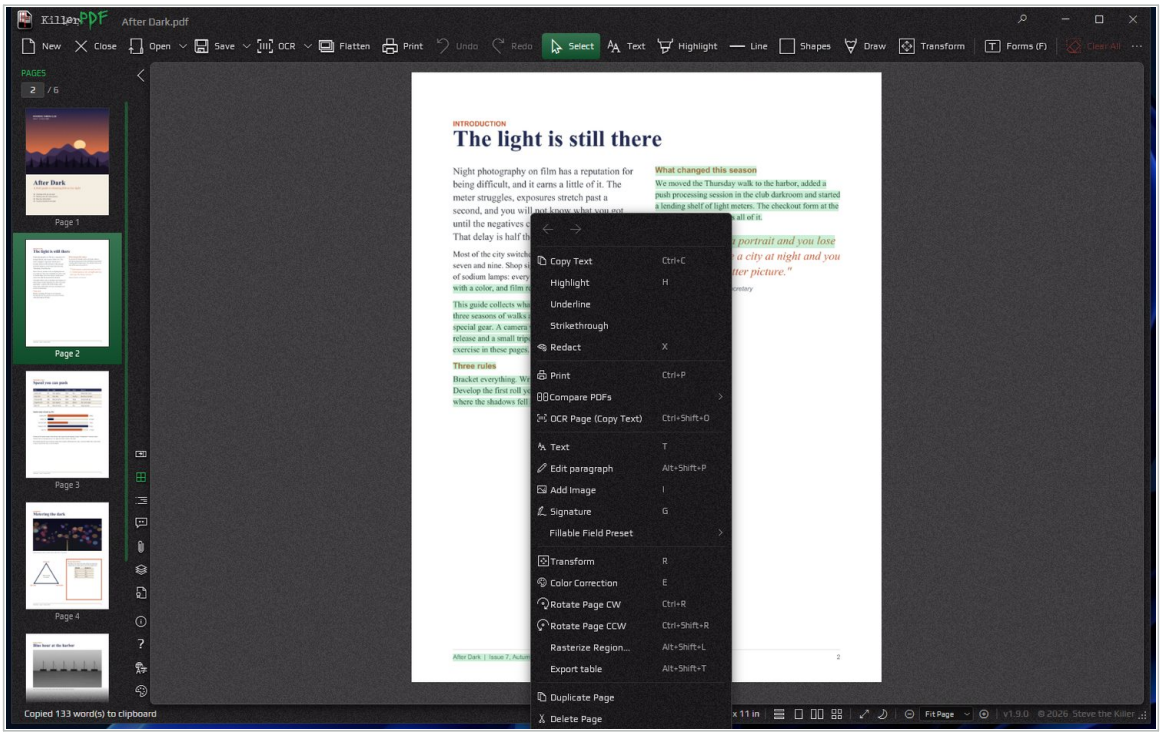
II

Markup and review

- Text, highlight, draw and shapes
- Images, measurements and comments
- Page numbers and watermarks

How markup works

Markup is how you put your own marks on a page. Drawn markup is written into the page content when you save, while measurements and comments stay real PDF annotations that reopen for editing.



Right-click a text selection to highlight, underline, strike through or redact it.

Tool keys

Tool	Default key
Select	V
Text	T
Highlight	H
Line	L or U
Shapes	O (Shift+O picks the next shape)
Draw	D
Add Image	I
Signature	G
Stamp Pages	S
Forms	F
Measure	M (Shift+M picks the next type)

Undo and Clear All

The Undo and Redo buttons cover annotations, text edits, stamps and document edits. Clear All on the toolbar removes every annotation. To clear one page, right-click it and choose Clear Page Annotations. The keys above are defaults, and you can remap them.

Select, group and arrange

The Select tool picks up anything you have drawn so you can move it, restyle it, stack it or delete it.

Work with what you drew

1. Press V or click Select on the toolbar.
2. Click an annotation to select it. Shift+click adds more to the selection.
3. Drag to move it. Double-click to edit it.
4. Press the arrow keys to nudge the selection. It stays inside the page.
5. Press Ctrl+C, then Ctrl+V to copy and paste.
6. Press Delete to remove the selection.
7. Right-click for Raise, Lower and Group selected.

Right-click menu

- Edit, Raise, Lower, Copy, Paste and Delete Selected.
- Raise and Lower are enabled only when something overlaps in that direction.
- Group selected, Ungroup and Remove from group.
- Select cover, Select text and Unpair text + cover for edited page text.
- A highlight drag across several lines is grouped per page, so it moves and deletes together.

> **Tip.** Changing a color, size or opacity on the tool bar while something is selected restyles that object.

Text and typewriter

Type onto a page, or click existing page text to edit that line in place.

How to use it

1. Press T or click Text on the toolbar.
2. Click the page and start typing.
3. Press Enter for a new line.
4. Press Ctrl+Enter to commit the box. Escape cancels.
5. To fix existing text, click it with the Text tool and edit the line.
6. Press Ctrl+B, Ctrl+I or Ctrl+U to toggle bold, italic or underline while typing.

Text bar

Option	What it does
Color, Fill	Text color and a background behind it
Size	8 to 72 points
Spacing	-2 to 20 points
Font	Any installed font family
Bold, Italic, Strikethrough, Underline	Toggles
Opacity, Fill Opacity	Text and background transparency

Good to know

- Editing an existing line temporarily shows its appearance in the text bar. Your defaults for new text stay separate.
- In a narrow window, expand the text bar's opacity controls when you need them.
- Ctrl+V pastes clipboard text as a text box. Escape cancels an active text edit.

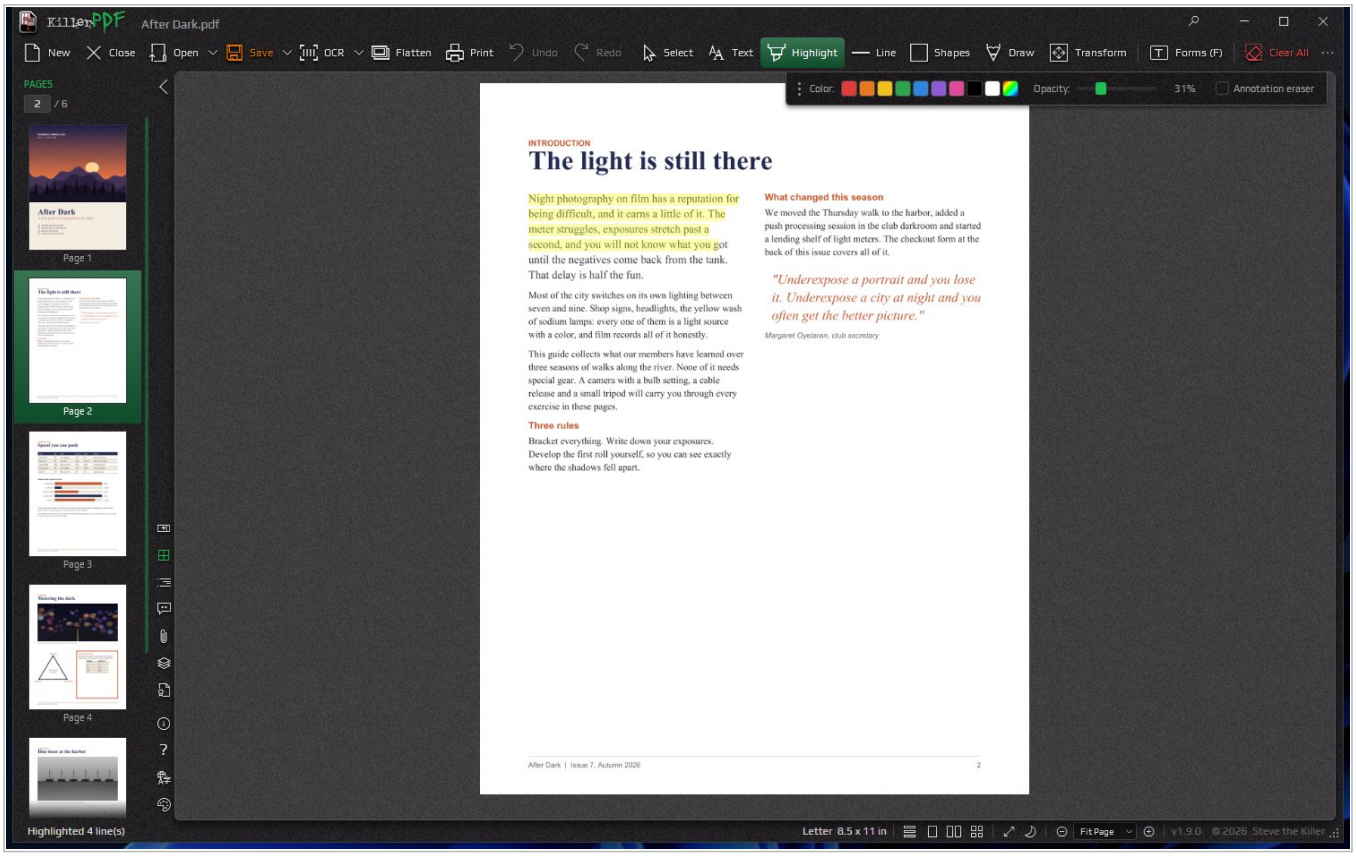
Edit a paragraph

1. Press Alt+Shift+P and select a paragraph on the page beside the editing options.
2. Resize its box with the corner handle or size fields, then edit the text and preview the result.
3. Review font substitutions, mixed-style warnings and uncertain word joins before applying.
4. Click Apply to replace the paragraph. If the text will not fit or cannot be edited safely, read the explanation and adjust your selection or options.

Scanned pages need OCR before paragraph editing. Tables, neighboring columns and overlapping content can prevent an edit. Unsupported shaping and unidentified characters are explained instead of silently changed.

Highlight, underline and strikethrough

Mark up the words you drag across. The mark follows the text lines instead of drawing a box.



Highlighted lines with the highlight bar.

How to use it

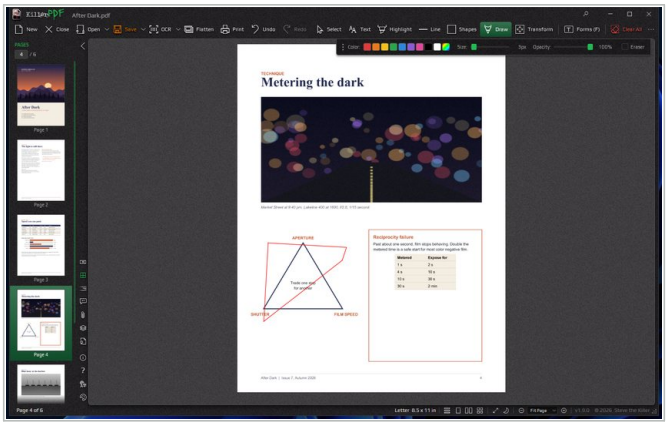
1. Press H or click Highlight on the toolbar.
2. Drag across the words. You get one highlight per line, and one Ctrl+Z reverts the whole drag.
3. For underline or strikethrough, select the text, right-click and choose Underline or Strikethrough.
4. To delete marks in bulk, tick Annotation eraser on the highlight bar and drag a box around them.

Good to know

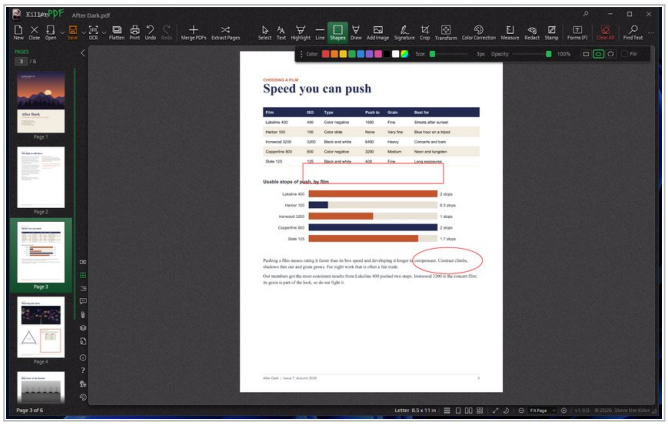
- The highlight bar has Color, Opacity and the Annotation eraser.
- Underline and strikethrough keep their own color and opacity. The default is opaque red.
- There is no toolbar button for underline or strikethrough.
- On a page with no text layer, KillerPDF shows a hint instead of drawing.

Draw, lines and shapes

Sketch freehand, draw straight lines, or drop in boxes, ellipses and freeform shapes.



Freehand ink with the draw bar.



A box, an ellipse and a freeform shape on a page.

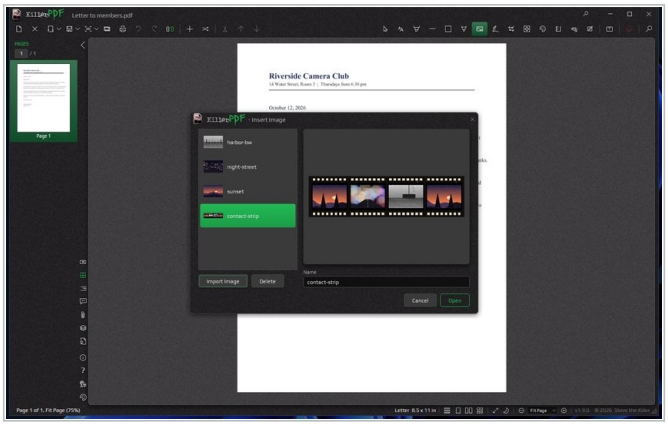
How to use it

1. Press D and drag to draw freehand.
2. Press L and drag for a straight line. Tick Level to keep it horizontal or vertical.
3. Press O and pick Box, Ellipse or Freeform.
4. Drag for a box or an ellipse.
5. For Freeform, click each point. Click the first point, double-click or press Enter to close. Backspace removes the last point.
6. Tick Eraser on the draw bar and brush over marks to delete them.

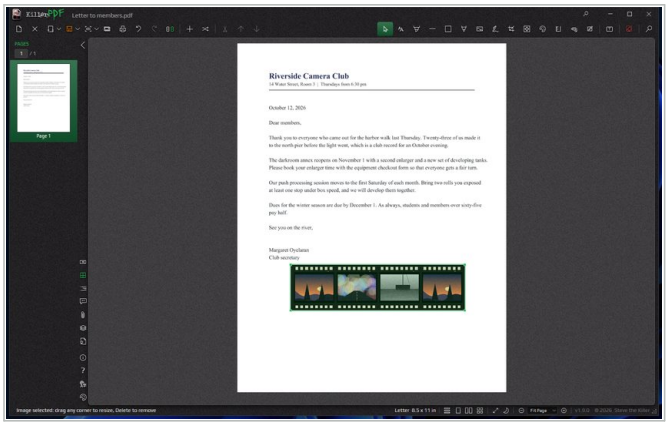
Option	Range
Size	1 to 60 px
Opacity	About 4 to 100 percent
Fill	On or off for shapes, on by default
Shift+O	Cycles Box, Ellipse, Freeform

Add Image and the image library

Put a logo, photo or scan on a page. Images you add are kept in a library you can reuse.



The image library with four saved photos.



A contact strip placed on the club letter, still selected for moving.

How to use it

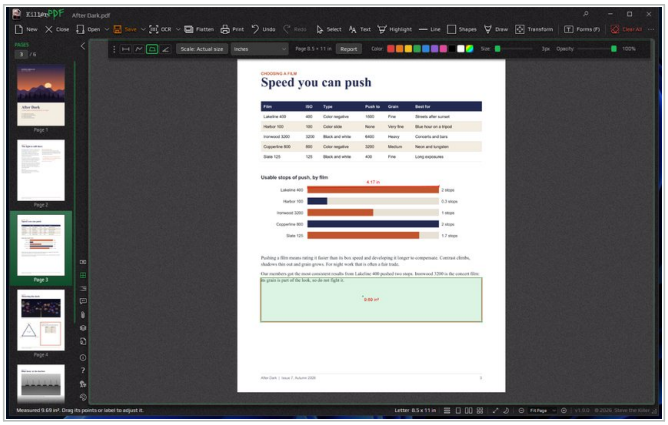
1. Press I or click the Image tool on the toolbar.
2. Click the page where the image should go. The image library opens.
3. Pick a saved image, or click Import Image to add a file, then click Open.
4. The image's top left corner lands where you clicked. Drag to move it, or drag the corner handle to resize it.

Good to know

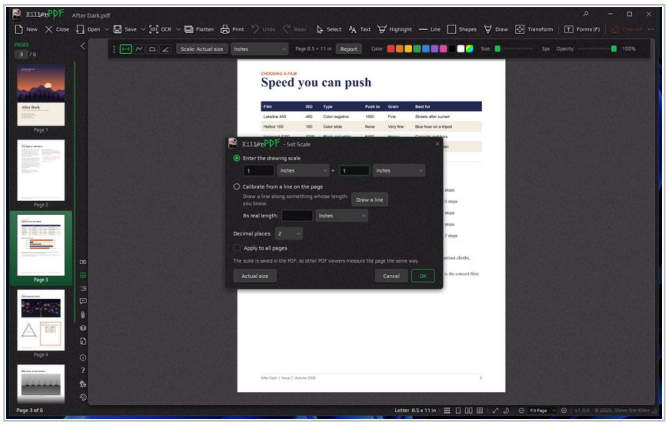
- Import accepts png, jpg, jpeg, bmp, gif, tiff and tif.
- A large image is shrunk to fit within half the page's longest side. A small one is not enlarged.
- Ctrl+V pastes a clipboard image onto the current page.
- Add Image is also in the page right-click menu.
- Watermarks and signatures use the same image library.

Measure

Measure distances, outlines, areas and angles on a page, at the scale of the drawing.



Distance and area measurements with the measure bar.



The Set Scale dialog.

How to use it

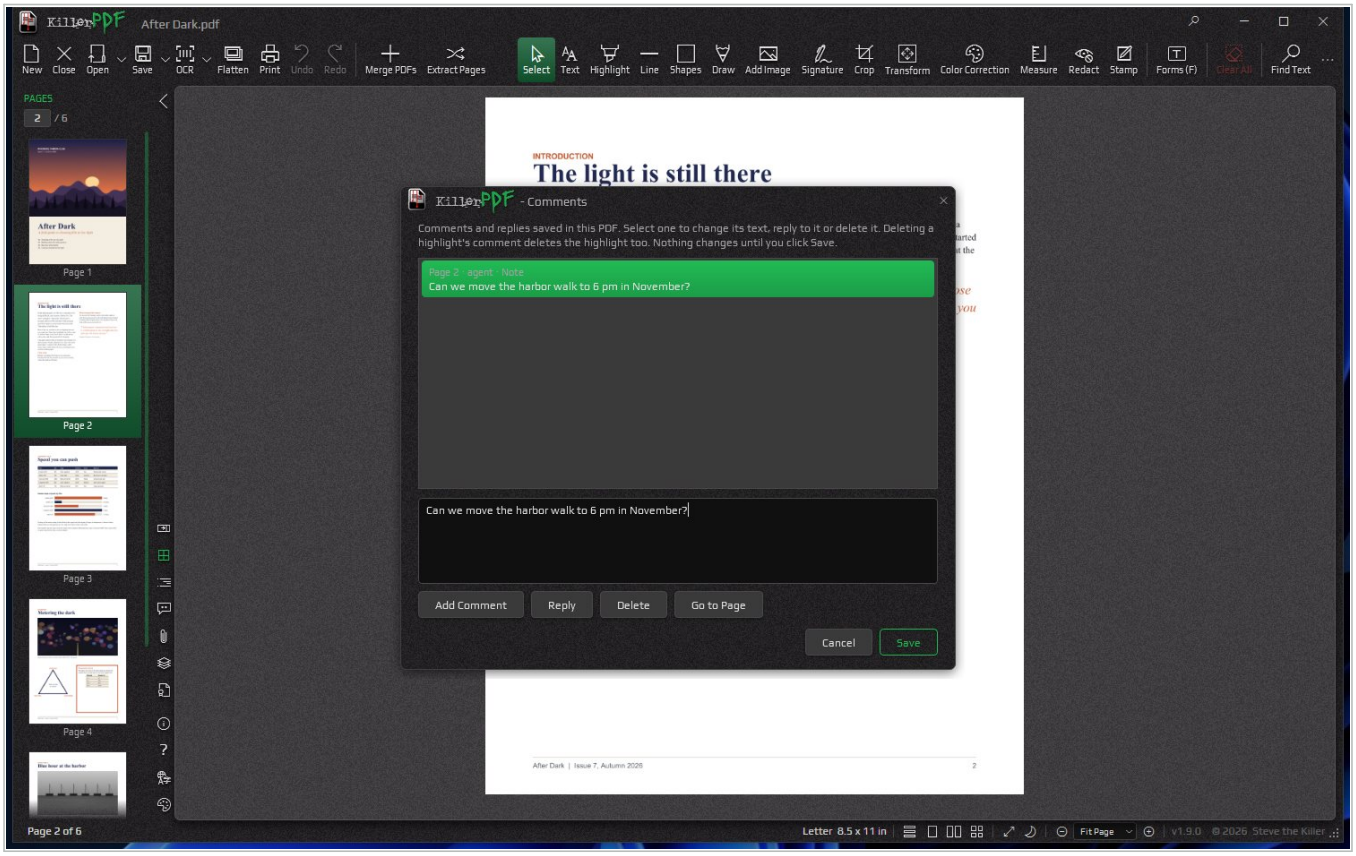
1. Press M, then pick a type. Shift+M steps to the next type.
2. Click the Scale button on the Measure bar (Alt+Shift+5) to open the Set Scale dialog.
3. Enter the drawing scale, or draw a line of known length and calibrate from it.
4. Pick a unit from the drop-down.
5. Measure. Backspace removes the last point and Esc cancels.
6. Click Report for every measurement, page by page.

Type	How you finish
Distance	Click two points, or drag
Perimeter	Click each corner, then double-click, press Enter or click the first point
Area	Click each corner, then click the first point or press Enter
Angle	Click one arm, the corner, then the other arm

- Points snap to the drawing's corners, lines and other measurements. Hold Alt to turn snapping off. Hold Shift for 45 degree steps.
- Nine units, from Inches to Kilometers.
- The report can be copied or saved as CSV or JSON.

Comments

Review comments and replies live in the Comments panel and the Comments dialog, including ones made in other readers.



The Comments dialog with a reply.

How to use it

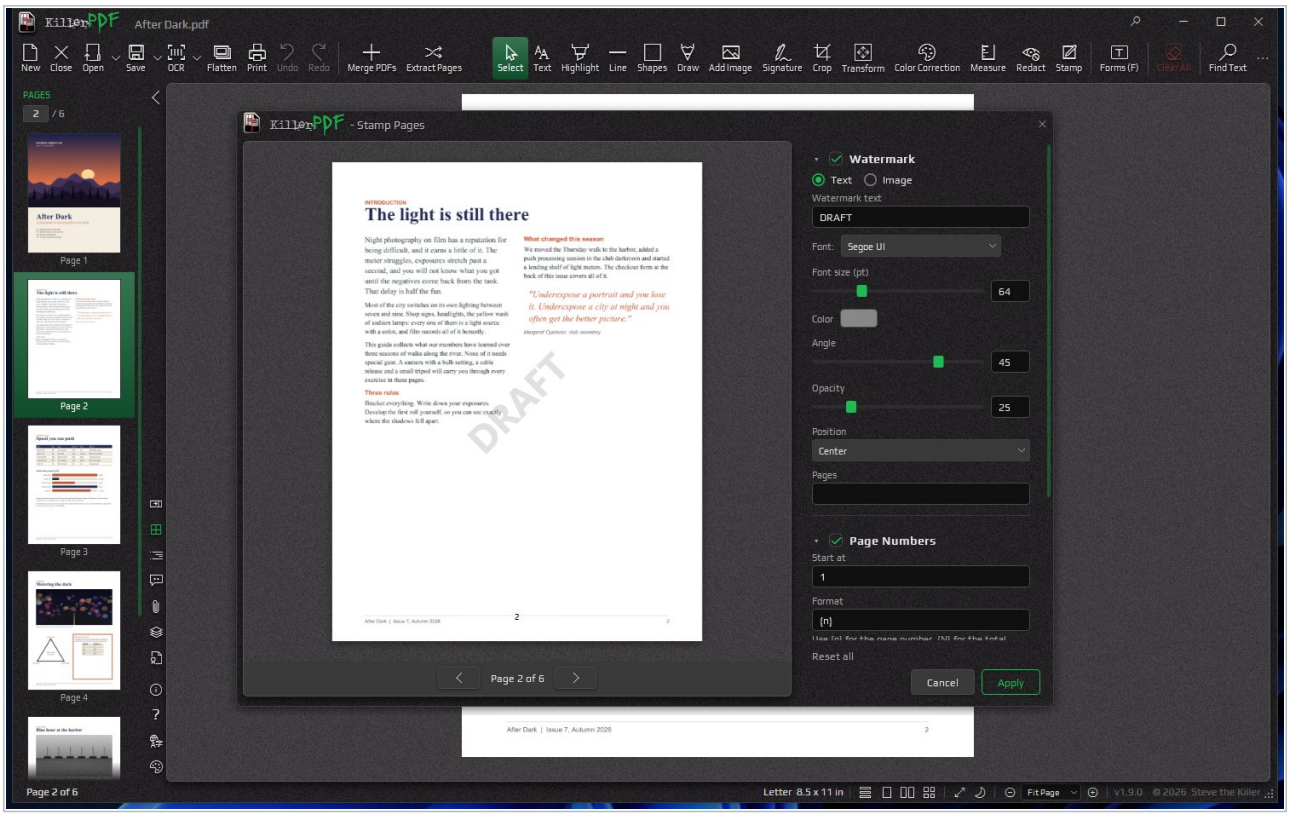
1. Press Alt+3 to open the Comments panel. Comments are grouped by page, with replies under their parent.
2. Use the All, Comments and Measurements chips to filter.
3. Click a row to jump to its page.
4. Double-click a row, or press Ctrl+Shift+D then K, to open the Comments dialog.
5. Edit the text, click Reply, Delete or Go to Page, or click Add Comment for a new note on the current page.
6. Save. Nothing is written until you do.

Good to know

- The author name is your Windows user name.
- A comment without a name in the file cannot take replies.
- Deleting a comment on a highlight deletes the highlight too.
- From the command line, killerpdf comments lists them.

Stamp Pages

Add page numbers, a watermark, or both, with a live preview before anything is applied.



Stamp Pages with page numbers and a watermark in the preview.

How to use it

1. Press S or click Stamp on the toolbar.
2. For page numbers, set Start at and Format. Use {n} for the current page and {N} for the total, as in Page {n} of {N}.
3. For a watermark, choose Text or Image.
4. Pick a position, or drag on the preview for a custom spot.
5. Set a page range such as 1-3,5. Leave it empty for all pages.
6. Step through the pages in the preview, then apply.

Option	Range
Page number size	6 to 96 pt
Watermark text size	12 to 200 pt, default DRAFT
Watermark image scale	10 to 200 percent
Watermark opacity	5 to 100 percent
Watermark angle	-90 to 90 degrees
Positions	Bottom Center, Bottom Right, Bottom Left, Top Center, Top Right, Top Left, Center, Custom

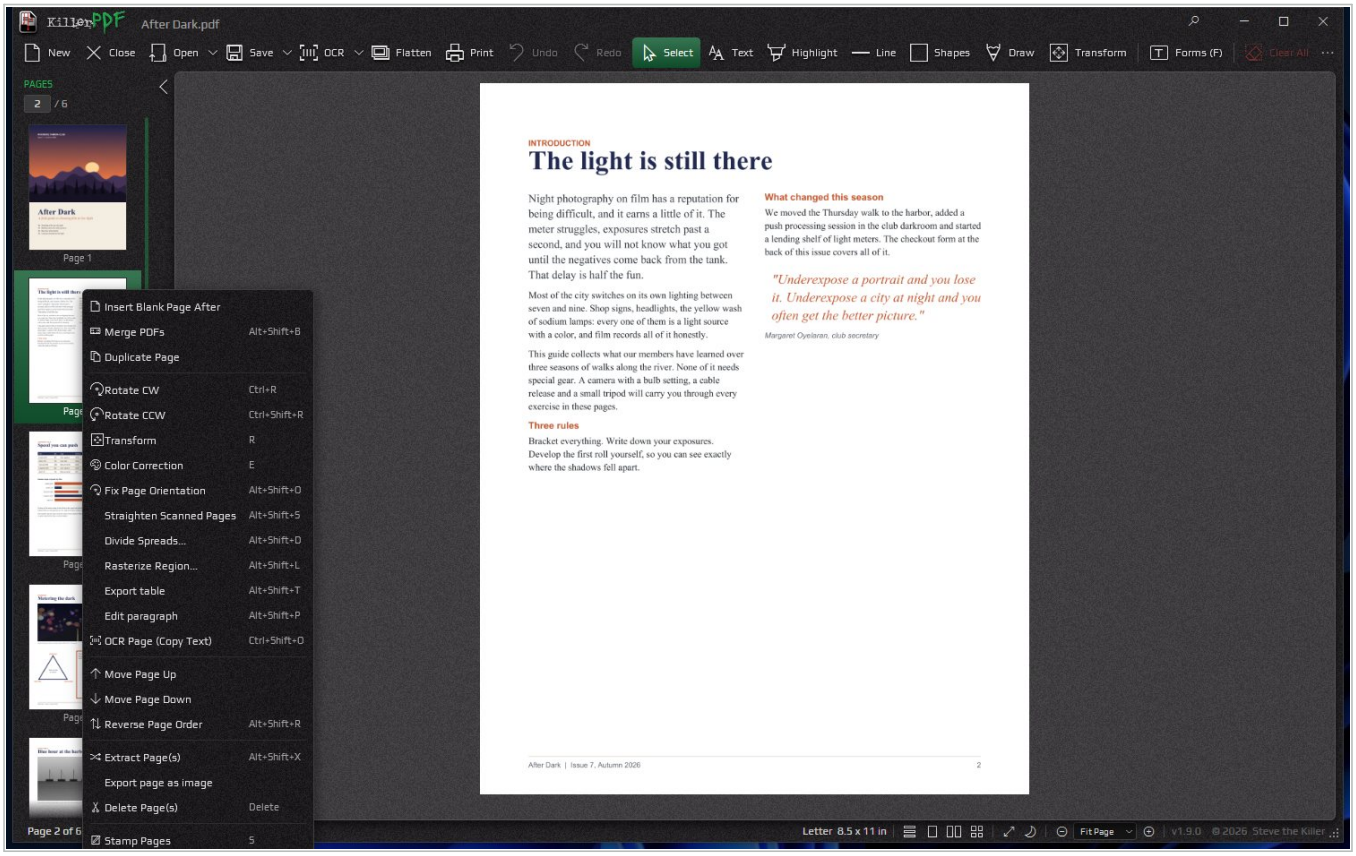
- Mirror on facing pages (outer edge) swaps sides on alternate pages.
- Reopen the tool, or double-click a placed stamp, to edit it. Turning both sections off removes the stamps.
- For Bates numbers or headers and footers, use killerpdf bates and number-pages.

Pages and documents

- Organize, crop and transform pages
- Scan, OCR and reduce file size
- Export, structure and print

The Pages panel

The Pages panel shows a thumbnail of every page. Most page work starts here, and each operation is one undo step.



The right-click menu on a page thumbnail.

Rearrange your pages

1. Press Alt+1 to open the Pages panel.
2. Click a thumbnail to select it. Ctrl-click or Shift-click to add more, or drag a box around several.
3. Drag the selection to a new spot. A line shows where the pages will land.
4. Right-click a thumbnail and choose Rotate CW, Duplicate Page or Insert Blank Page After.
5. Press Del to delete the selected pages, then confirm.
6. To copy pages into another document, press F10 for a split view and drag the thumbnails across.
7. Drop PDF or image files on the list to insert them at the line.

Good to know

- Rotate CW is Ctrl+R and Rotate CCW is Ctrl+Shift+R.
- Add Blank Page (Alt+Shift+A) offers Current page, Letter, A4, Legal or Custom, from 0.1 to 200 inches.
- Delete will not remove the last remaining page.
- Annotations and rotations travel with pages dragged to the other pane.
- A file opened read-only because of owner restrictions refuses page edits until you unlock it.

Merge, extract, split and reorder

Put documents together, pull pages out, or cut a file apart. Merge and extract live on the toolbar. Split is a command line feature.

Combine and pull apart

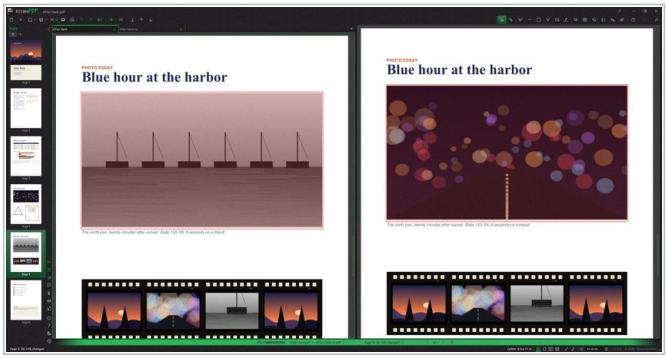
1. Click Merge PDFs on the toolbar (Alt+Shift+B) and pick one or more PDFs. Their pages go on the end.
2. To insert in the middle, right-click a thumbnail and choose Merge PDFs. The pages go after that one.
3. To merge images, drop JPG, PNG, BMP, GIF or TIFF files on the window and choose Merge into one PDF.
4. To extract, press Alt+Shift+X, type a range such as 1-3,5,9-12, and save the new PDF.
5. To reverse the order, press Alt+Shift+R. With two or more pages selected, only those reverse.
6. To number pages with letters or roman numerals, press Ctrl+Shift+D, then G, and edit the page label ranges.

Good to know

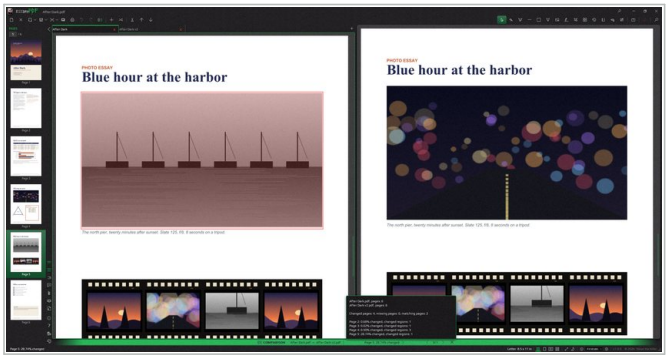
- A drop takes at most 50 files, after a confirmation. Folders and ZIP archives work too.
- A damaged file triggers an offer to repair a copy first. The original is never written.
- Page label styles: Decimal, Uppercase Roman, Lowercase Roman, Uppercase letters, Lowercase letters, Prefix only.
- Split runs from the command line with killerpdf split: one PDF per page by default, or every N pages, N equal parts, at bookmarks, or by maximum size. Use one rule at a time.

Compare two PDFs

Compare puts two versions side by side, keeps them scrolled and zoomed together, and outlines what changed on each page.



Two issues of the club guide compared on page 5, with the changed photo outlined on both sides.



The report lists the changed share and the changed regions for every page.

How to compare

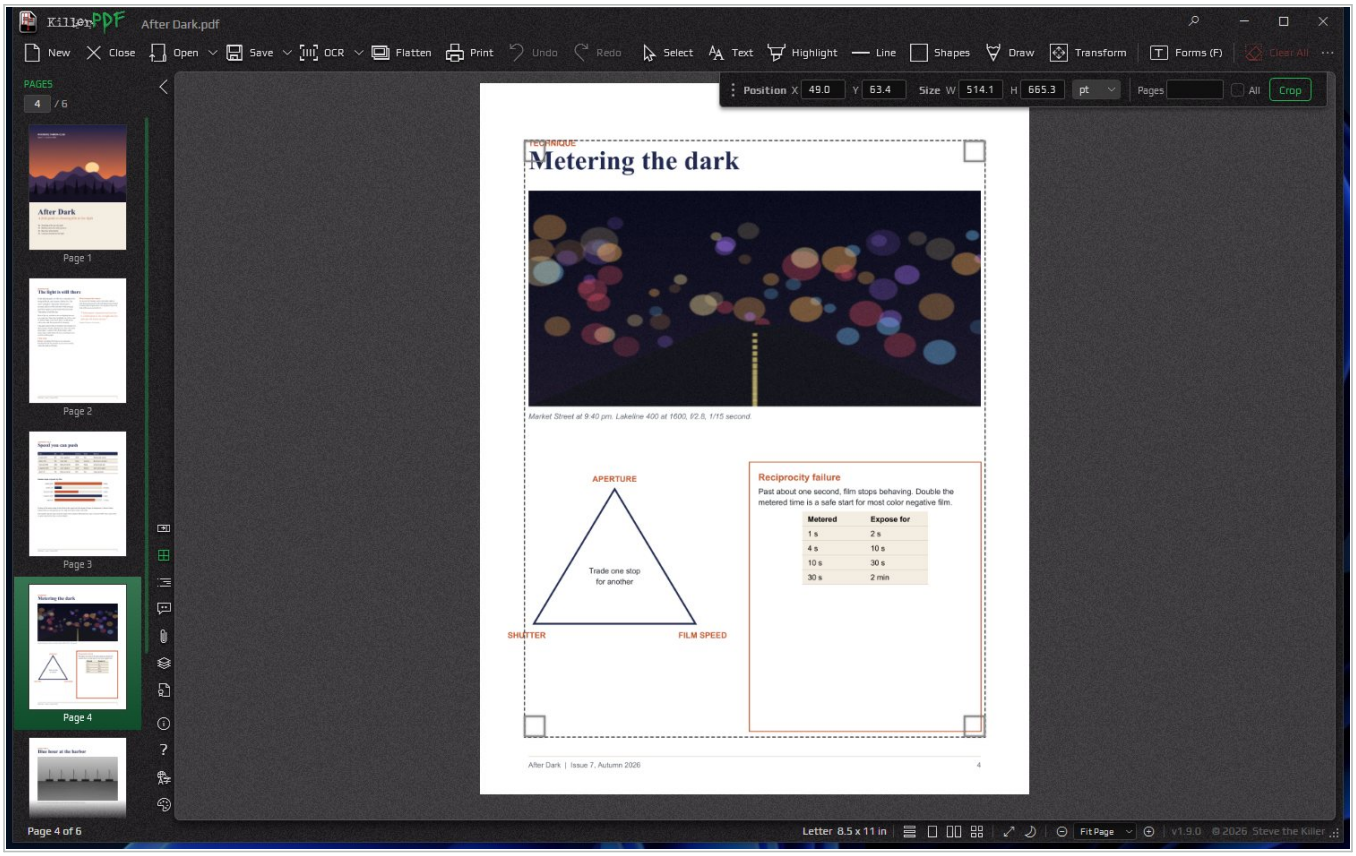
1. Open the first PDF.
2. Click Compare PDFs on the toolbar or press Alt+Shift+V.
3. Pick another open tab, or choose Choose another PDF to pick a file.
4. Scroll or zoom either side. The other side follows.
5. Use the arrows on the comparison bar to step through the changed regions on the page.
6. Click the page result on the bar for a report on every page.
7. Press Escape or click Compare PDFs again to end the comparison.

Good to know

- The comparison opens on the page you were reading.
- Changes are found by comparing the rendered pages, so a moved photo or a recolored chart shows up even when the text is identical.
- A page that exists in only one PDF is named on the bar and in the report.
- Pages of different sizes are reported as dimensions that differ.

Crop

Crop sets the visible area of a page. Drag the rectangle, or type exact values.



The crop rectangle on a page with the crop bar.

Crop pages

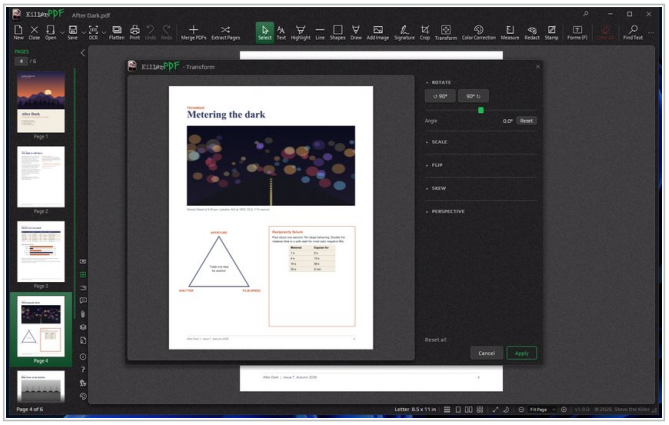
1. Press C or click Crop on the toolbar. A rectangle appears inset 8% from every edge.
2. Drag the rectangle, or type X, Y, W and H. Choose points, inches or percent. The origin is the top left.
3. To crop more pages, type a range such as 1-3,5 in the Pages box, or tick All. Blank means the current page.
4. Press Enter or click Crop to apply. Press Esc to cancel.

Good to know

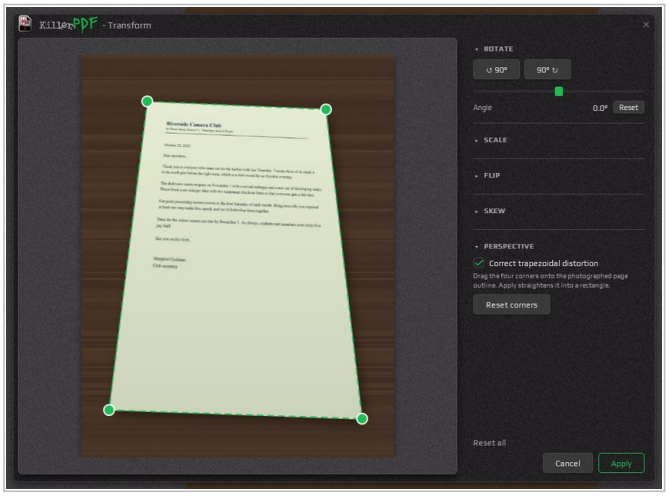
- Pages of different sizes are scaled proportionally, and each crop stays inside the page.
- A crop hides the outside area. It does not delete it, so use Redact for anything that must be gone.
- Crop is not available on the command line or as a macro step.

Transform and perspective

Transform rotates, scales, flips, straightens and levels a page with a live preview. Perspective fixes pages photographed at an angle.



The Transform window with its sections.



Corner handles dragged onto a letter photographed at an angle.

Fix a page

1. Press R or click Transform. Closing the window without Apply changes nothing.
2. Rotate with the 90 degree buttons or the slider.
3. For a crooked scan, choose Draw a level line and drag along something that should be level, like a line of text.
4. For a photographed page, turn on Correct trapezoidal distortion and drag the four corners onto the page outline.
5. Adjust scale, flip, levels and page quality, and watch the preview.
6. Click Apply.

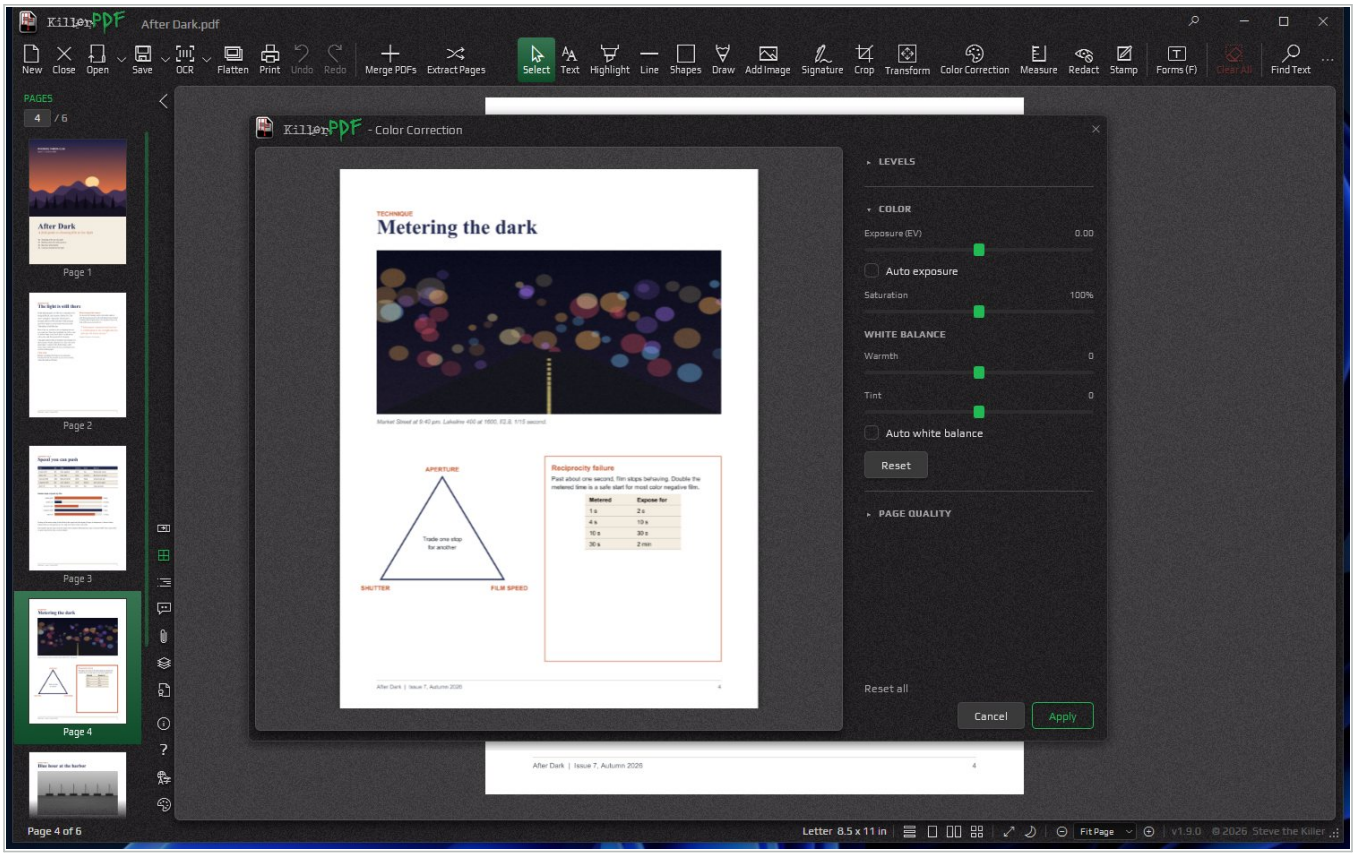
Ranges

Control	Range
Rotate slider	-45 to +45 degrees, 0.1 steps
Scale	25% to 200%
Black point	0 to 200
White point	55 to 255
Midtones	0.2 to 2.5
Output resolution	72 to 600 DPI
JPEG quality	25% to 100%

Tip. Transform rasterizes each page, so selectable text is lost. A batch of pages is one undo step.

Color correction

Color correction fixes exposure and white balance on pages that came out dark, flat or tinted.



The Color correction tool with its sliders.

Correct a page

1. Select the pages in the Pages panel.
2. Press E, or right-click and choose Color Correction.
3. Move Exposure, Saturation, Warmth and Tint, or use the Auto options for exposure and white balance.
4. Check the preview. Reset puts a section back to normal.
5. Click Apply.

Ranges

Control	Range
Exposure	-3 to +3 EV
Saturation	0 to 200%
Warmth	-100 to +100
Tint	-100 to +100

> **Tip.** Color correction shares its window with Transform and rasterizes the page, so selectable text is lost.

Scanning and scan cleanup

Scan straight into KillerPDF, then clean the pages up. Fix tilt, turn pages upright and split two-page spreads.

Scan and clean up

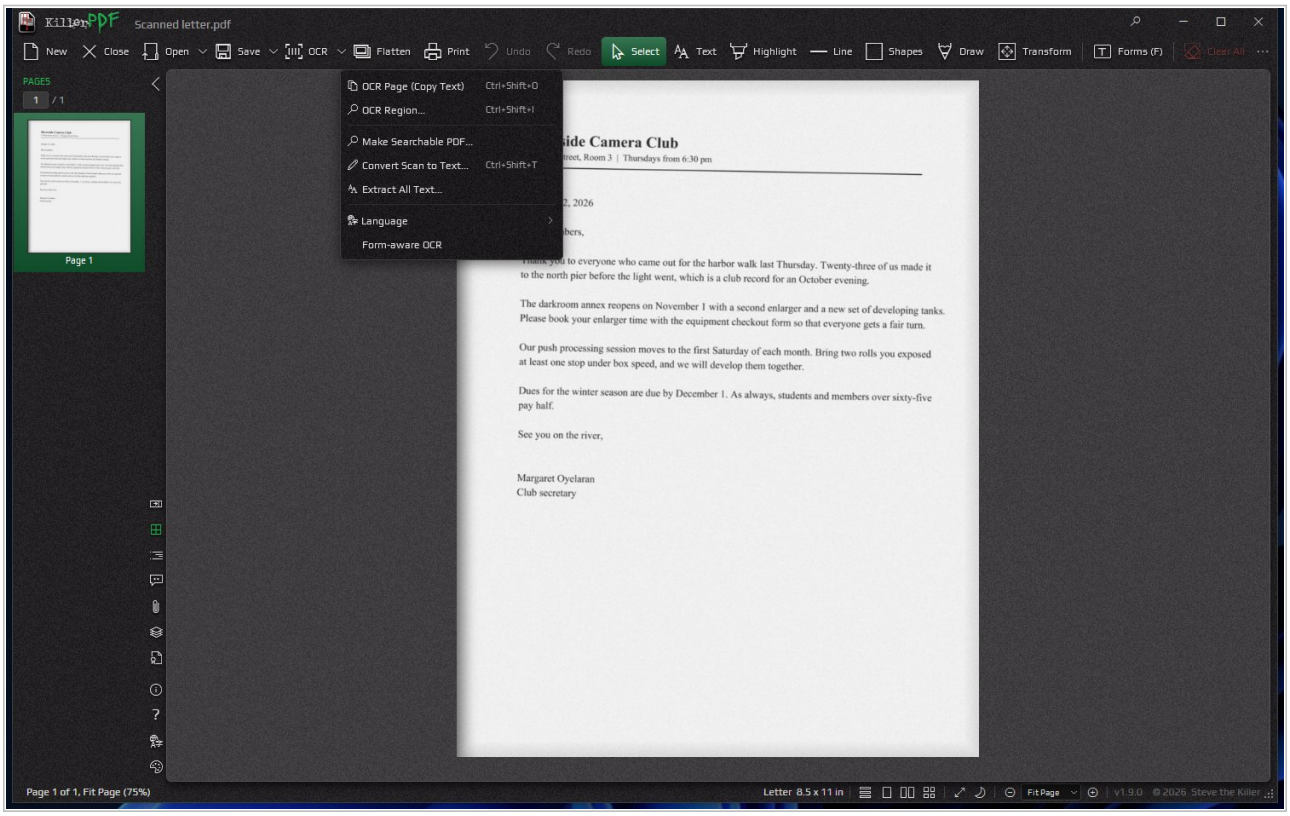
1. Click the arrow beside Open and choose Scan...
2. Pick your scanner. You can show its own settings window for color, resolution and pages.
3. Scan. The pages open as a new, unsaved PDF.
4. Press Alt+Shift+S to straighten tilted scans.
5. Press Alt+Shift+O to turn pages upright.
6. Press Alt+Shift+D to divide two-page spreads.
7. To give a PDF a scanned look, press Alt+Shift+F and tick the Scanned look effects.

Good to know

- Scanning needs the 64-bit TWAIN manager (TWAINDSM.dll), which scanner drivers install.
- Straighten changes only scans without a text layer and ignores tilt under 0.15 degrees. Run it before OCR.
- Fix Page Orientation reads text direction. On scans it uses OCR, so it may offer to download a language model.
- Divide Spreads: Left and right pages or Top and bottom pages, divider between 5% and 95%, for this page, selected pages or all pages.
- Scanned look effects: tilt, warm paper tone, scanner grain, soft focus, edge shadow.

OCR

OCR reads the text in a scan. You can copy it, add a hidden text layer so the scan becomes searchable, or turn the scan into real text.



The OCR drop-down with the language list.

Make a scan searchable

1. Click the arrow on the OCR button to open the OCR menu.
2. Open Language and tick one or more. At least one stays ticked.
3. Choose Make Searchable PDF... KillerPDF suggests the file name name-searchable.pdf and adds an invisible text layer. Esc cancels.
4. Or choose Convert Scan to Text... (Ctrl+Shift+T) to replace scanned words with real text.
5. In Review Converted Words, check each word as scanned beside its text version. Clear a word to keep it as a scan.
6. Click Save Converted PDF.

Languages and models

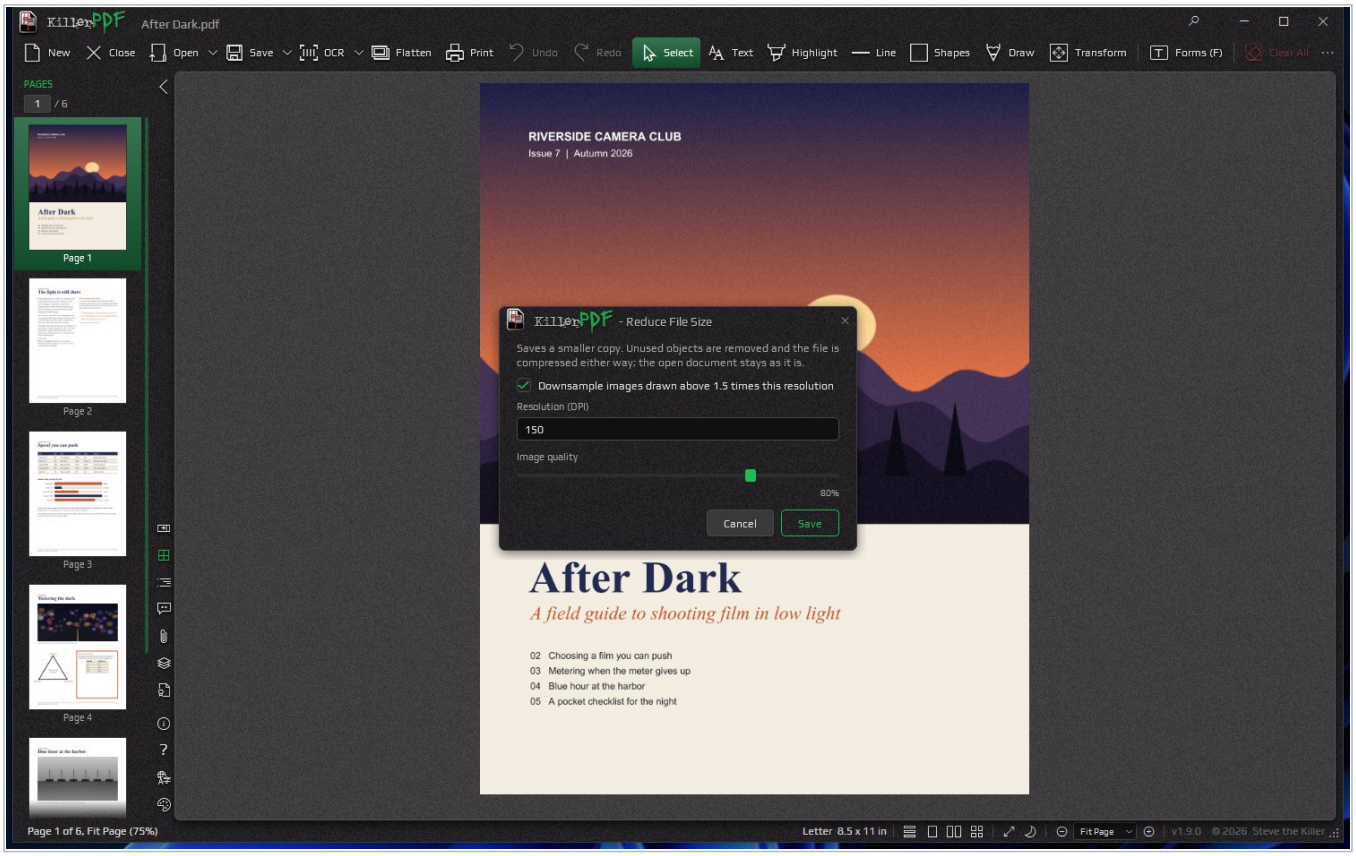
English, Bengali, Czech, German, Spanish, French, Hungarian, Italian, Japanese, Kazakh, Norwegian, Polish, Portuguese, Russian, Slovenian, Turkish, Ukrainian, Vietnamese, Chinese (Simplified) and Chinese (Traditional). No model ships in the program, English included. KillerPDF asks before the first download, and Use High Quality Models switches to the larger set.

Also in the menu

- OCR Page (Copy Text) is Ctrl+Shift+O. OCR Region is Ctrl+Shift+I.
- Extract All Text saves a .txt or .md file.
- On the command line, killerpdf scan-to-text can also write a review folder.

Reduce file size

Reduce File Size saves a smaller copy and leaves your open document alone.



The Reduce File Size options.

Shrink a file

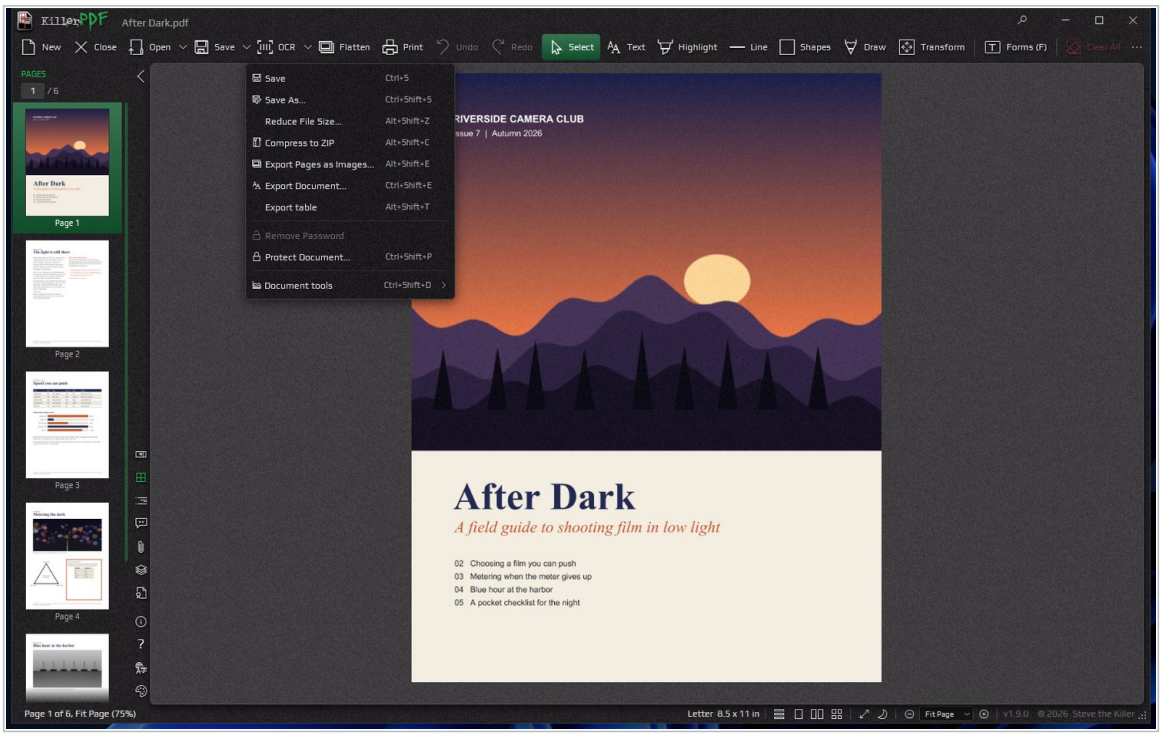
1. Click the arrow beside Save and choose Reduce File Size... (Alt+Shift+Z).
2. Unused objects are removed and the file is compressed in every case.
3. To shrink images, tick the downsample option. Set a DPI from 36 to 1200 (default 150).
4. Set image quality from 25% to 100% (default 80%).
5. Click Save and choose a name. The status line shows the size before and after, and how many images were resampled.

Good to know

- Images are downsampled only when drawn above 1.5 times the DPI you set.
- On the command line, killerpdf optimize can also strip metadata, attachments, javascript, comments, thumbnails, bookmarks, forms, xfa, openaction and layers.
- A signed destination asks before replacing.
- Guided tasks include Prepare for email, which optimizes without reducing image quality.

Export and conversion

Turn a PDF into other formats, or bring Word, Excel and image files in as PDFs.



The export choices under the Save arrow.

Export a PDF

1. Click the arrow beside Save and choose Export Document... (Ctrl+Shift+E).
2. Pick a format.
3. Type a page range, or leave it blank for all pages.
4. For Word or PowerPoint, choose Editable content or Page pictures.
5. Read the list of export limitations if one appears, then save.

Formats out

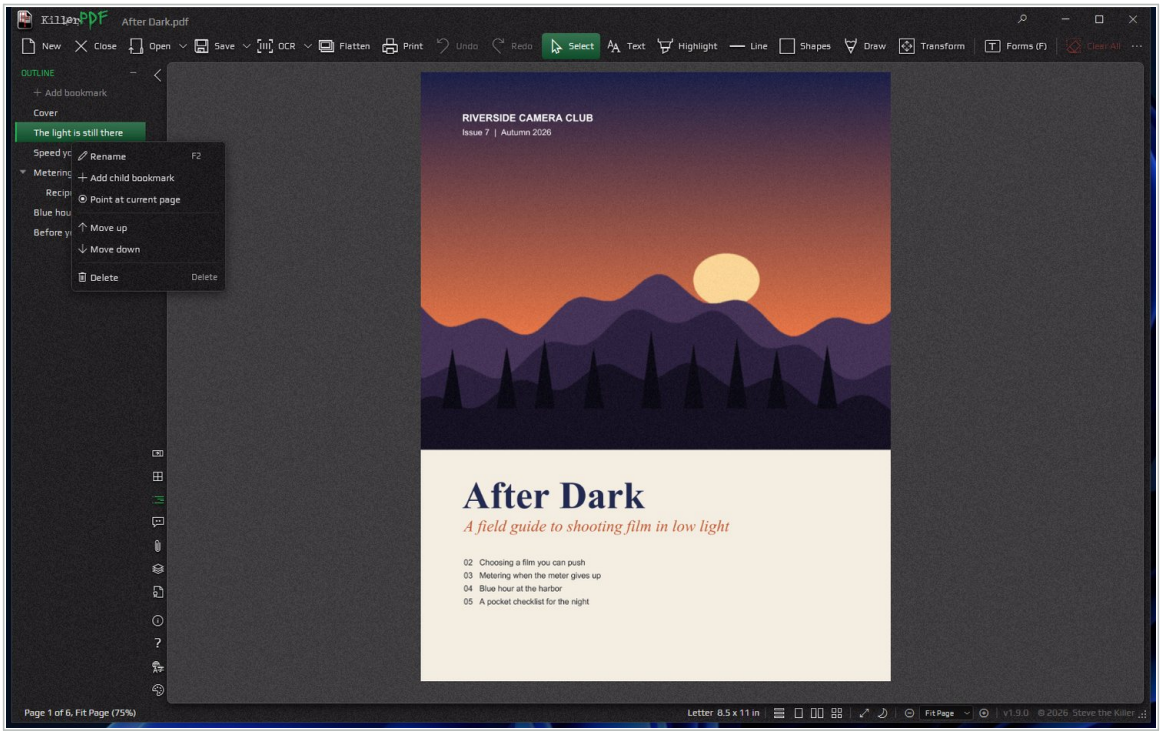
Format	File
Word	.docx
Excel	.xlsx
PowerPoint	.pptx
HTML	.html
Markdown	.md
Plain text	.txt
JSON	.json

Also

- Export Pages as Images (Alt+Shift+E) writes PNG or JPEG at 24 to 1200 DPI, default 150.
- Export table (Alt+Shift+T) saves a table you box to XLSX or CSV.
- Convert Word or Excel file... under the Open arrow takes .docx, .doc, .xlsx and .xls. Old .doc and .xls files need Word or Excel installed.

Bookmarks and document structure

Bookmarks, contents pages, page labels, attachments and layers make a long document easier to move through.



Editing bookmarks in the Outline panel.

Build bookmarks and contents

1. Press Alt+2 for the Outline panel. Add, rename (F2), move and drag bookmarks.
2. For a quick start, press Ctrl+Shift+D, then B, to create bookmarks from headings.
3. Set minimum heading size (default 14 points) and depth (default 6).
4. Tick the proposals you want, edit titles and levels, and click Add selected.
5. Press Ctrl+Shift+D, then I, to insert a clickable table of contents at the front.

Document tools (Ctrl+Shift+D, then the letter)

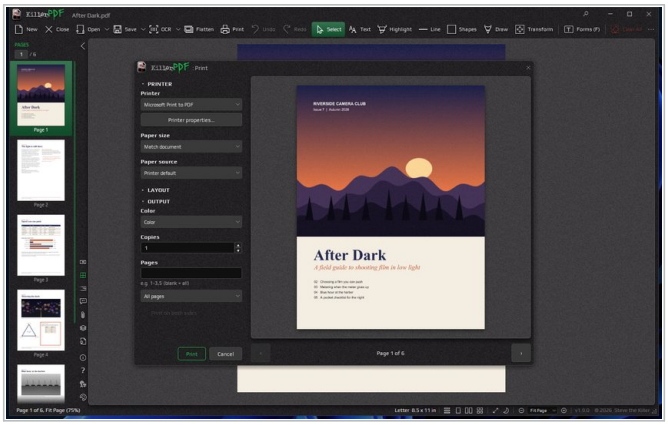
Letter	Tool
G	Edit page labels
V	Initial view settings
T	Edit attachments
O	Edit portfolio
E	Edit layers
N	Navigation audit

Good to know

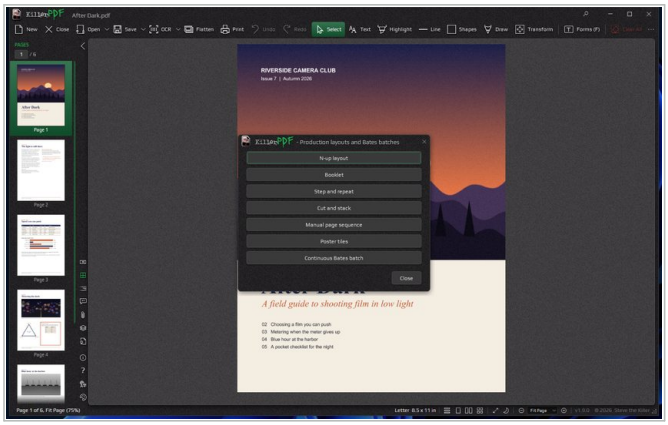
- The contents page is built from bookmarks, 40 entries per page, so add them first.
- Layers are shown and hidden in the Layers panel (Alt+5). Locked layers cannot be toggled.
- Attachments are in the Attachments panel (Alt+4).

Printing and production layouts

Print from a preview window, or lay pages out for booklets, sheets and numbered batches.



The print window with the page preview.



Production layouts and Bates batches.

Print a document

1. Press Ctrl+P.
2. Pick the printer, paper size and orientation.
3. Choose Scale, Margins and Pages per sheet.
4. Set Copies, a page range, and odd or even pages.
5. Click Print when the preview finishes.

Print limits

- Pages per sheet: 1, 2, 4, 6 or 9. Copies: 1 to 9999. Custom scale: 1% to 1000%.
- Final pages are rendered at 300 DPI before spooling.

Production layouts (Ctrl+Shift+D, then O)

Layout
N-up layout
Booklet
Step and repeat
Cut and stack
Manual page sequence
Poster tiles
Continuous Bates batch

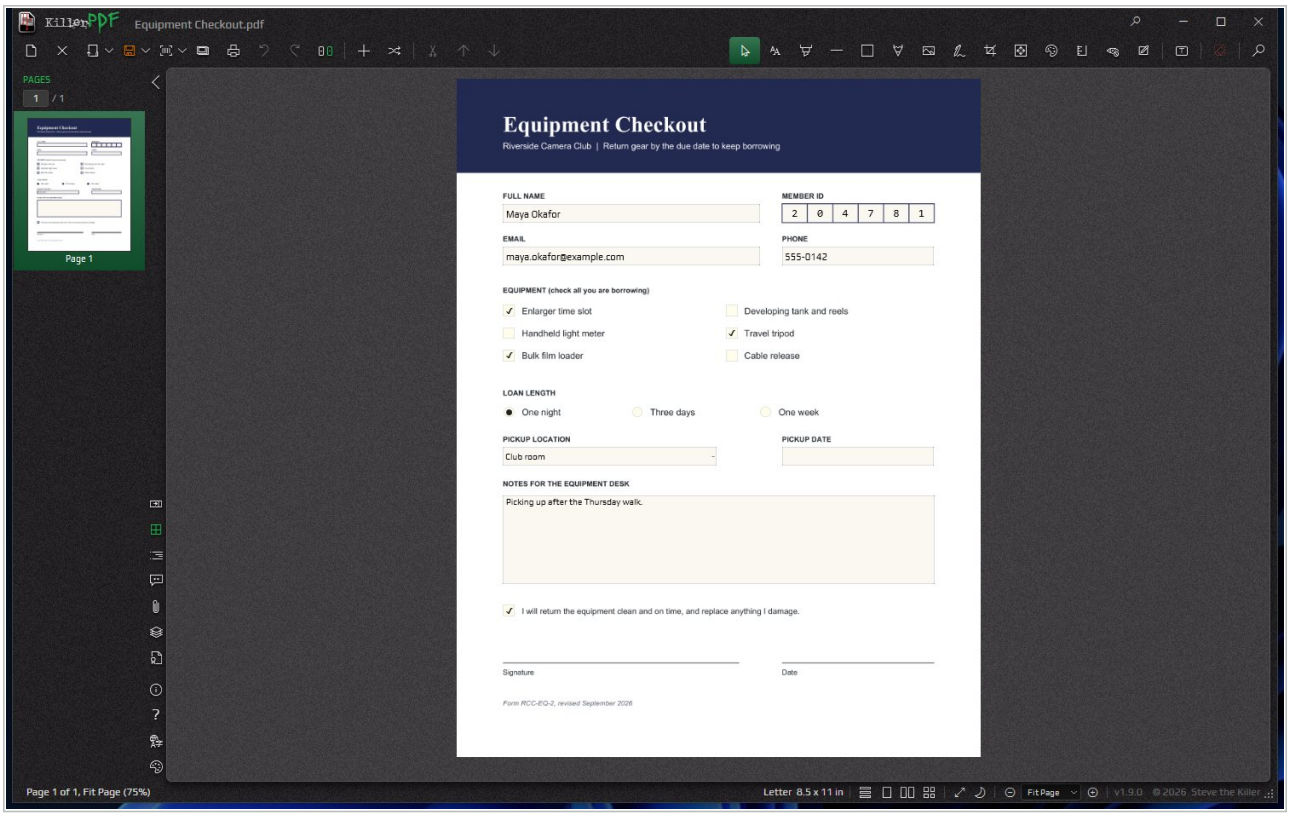
IV

Forms and signatures

- Fill and create forms
- Form data and Data Merge
- Visual and digital signatures

Filling forms

Open a fillable PDF and double-click into the fields. You do not need a special tool.



The checkout form being filled in.

How to fill a form

1. Open the PDF.
2. Double-click a text field and type. Tab moves to the next field.
3. Pick from drop-downs and list boxes.
4. Tick check boxes and radio buttons.
5. Click a signature or initials field to place a saved visual signature.
6. Save.

Field types you can fill

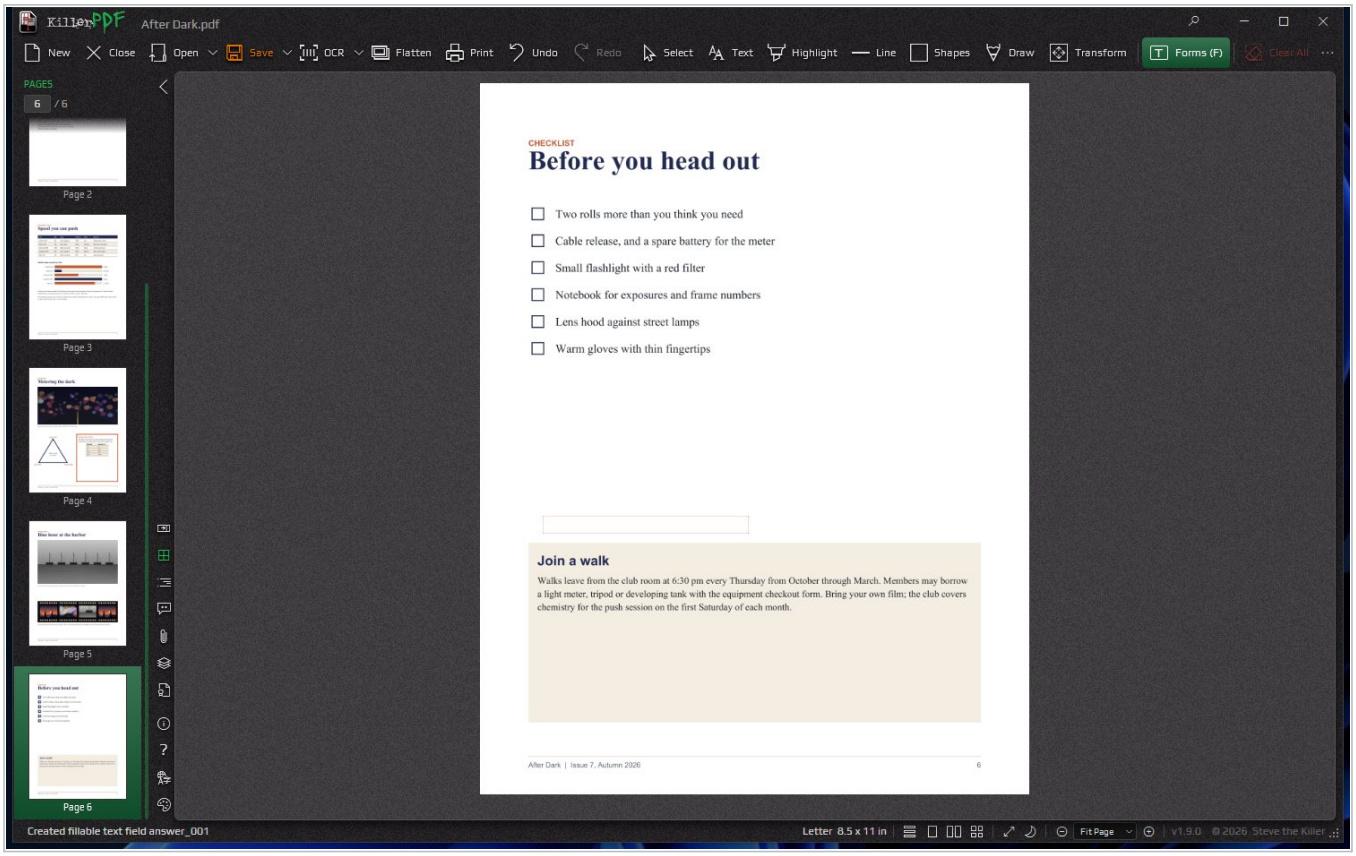
- Text: single line, multiline, comb and password.
- Drop-down and multi-select list box.
- Check box and radio buttons.
- Signature and initials fields. These are visual marks, not digital signatures.
- Read-only fields are disabled and push buttons are skipped.
- Calculated fields update when you commit a value. Unsupported scripts are not run.
- With the Select tool, a single click on a text field selects it so it can be moved; a double-click edits it.

Restricted forms

If the owner blocks editing but allows form filling, you can fill the form and save it. The file keeps its encryption and permissions. This works only when you have added no drawn markup, stamps or redaction marks. Anything else needs the owner password, through the Enter Owner Password button.

Creating form fields

Turn a flat page into a fillable form by drawing fields, or let KillerPDF find the fields for you.



Placing a new text field with the Forms tool.

Add fields

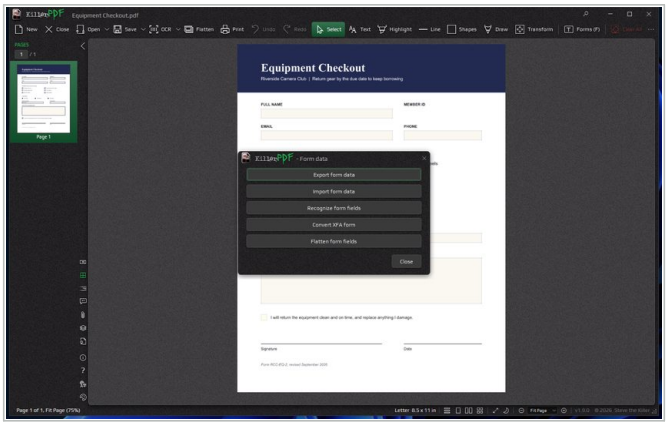
1. Press F or click Forms on the toolbar.
2. Drag a rectangle on the page to make a text field.
3. Drag a field to move it. Drag the corner grip to resize it. Press Delete to remove it.
4. Right-click a field for Fill Color or Save as Field Preset.
5. To let KillerPDF find fields, press Ctrl+Shift+D, then H, then choose Recognize form fields.
6. Tick the fields to add, rename them if you like, and confirm.

Good to know

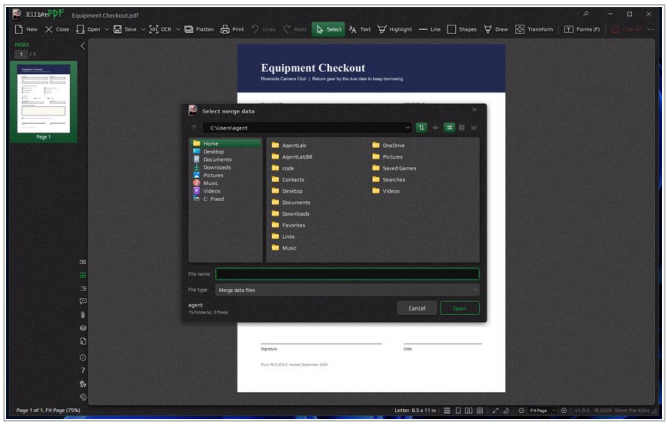
- You can create text fields and check boxes. Radio groups, drop-downs and list boxes can be filled but not created.
- Recognition looks for stroked rectangles on the page, from 8 to 60 points tall. Small squares become check boxes.
- A new field is named answer_001, answer_002 and so on, and is multiline when it is tall enough.
- A preset keeps size, font size, colors and border, and works in any document.
- Convert XFA form is in the same menu.

Form data and Data Merge

Move answers in and out of a form, or fill one template once per row of a data file.



The Form data window.



The Data merge window.

Form data (Ctrl+Shift+D, then H)

Direction	Formats
Export form data	XFDF (default), FDF or JSON
Import form data	FDF or XFDF

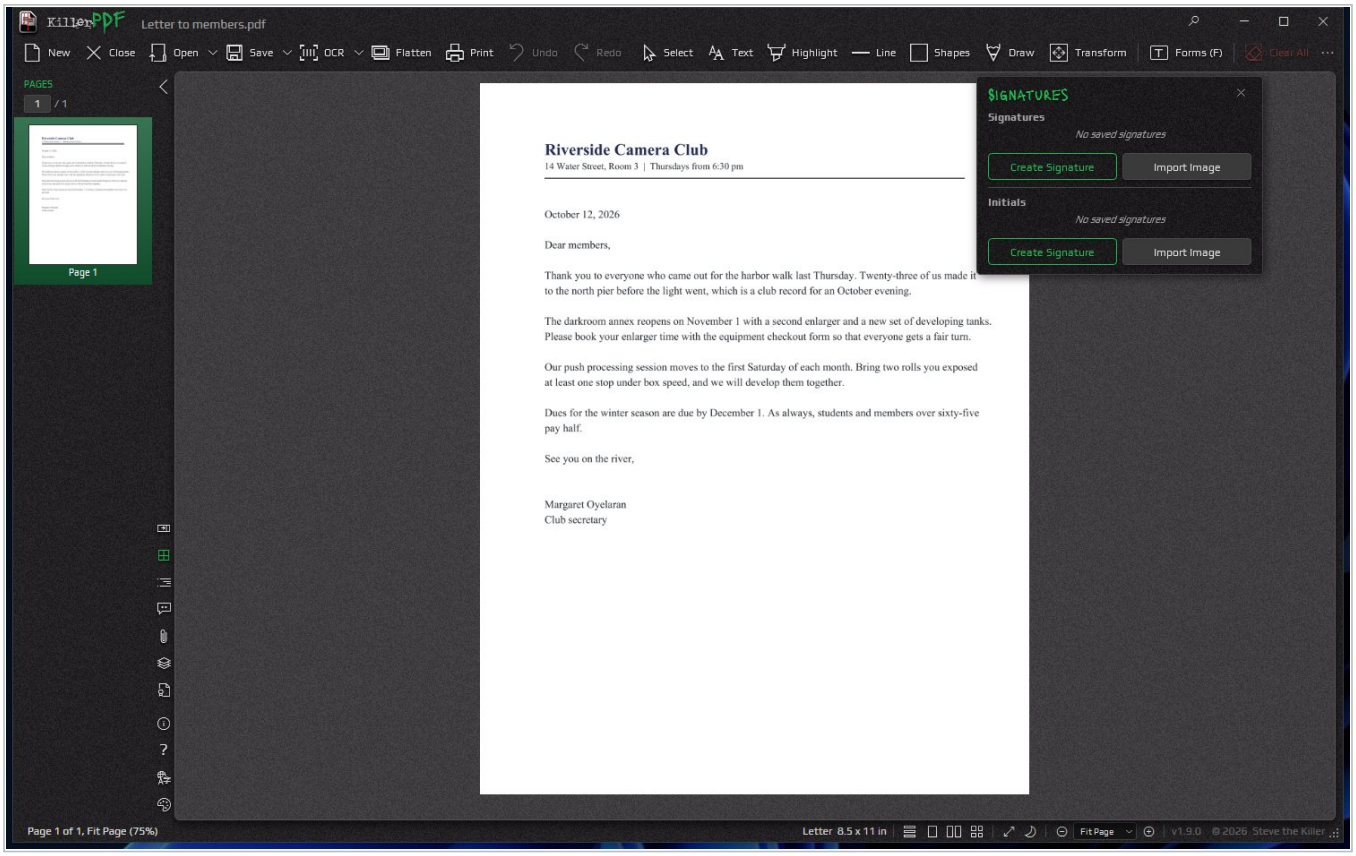
Merge a template with a data file

1. Open the form that will be the template.
2. Press Ctrl+Shift+D, then D.
3. Pick a CSV, JSON or XLSX file.
4. Name the first output file.
5. Check the mapping. Columns match fields with the same name, ignoring case. Add or change mappings if needed.
6. Review and run. A report shows how many records succeeded and failed.

- Import shows a preview of matching and skipped fields and can flatten after importing.
- CSV is for Data Merge only, not form data.
- You get one PDF per record, editable or flattened.
- Mappings save as a JSON profile.
- Page text can be filled with {{name}} placeholders through a Text placeholder mapping; every placeholder you map must be found in the page text.

Visual signatures and initials

Draw or import your signature once, then place it on any document.



Drawing a visual signature.

Create and place

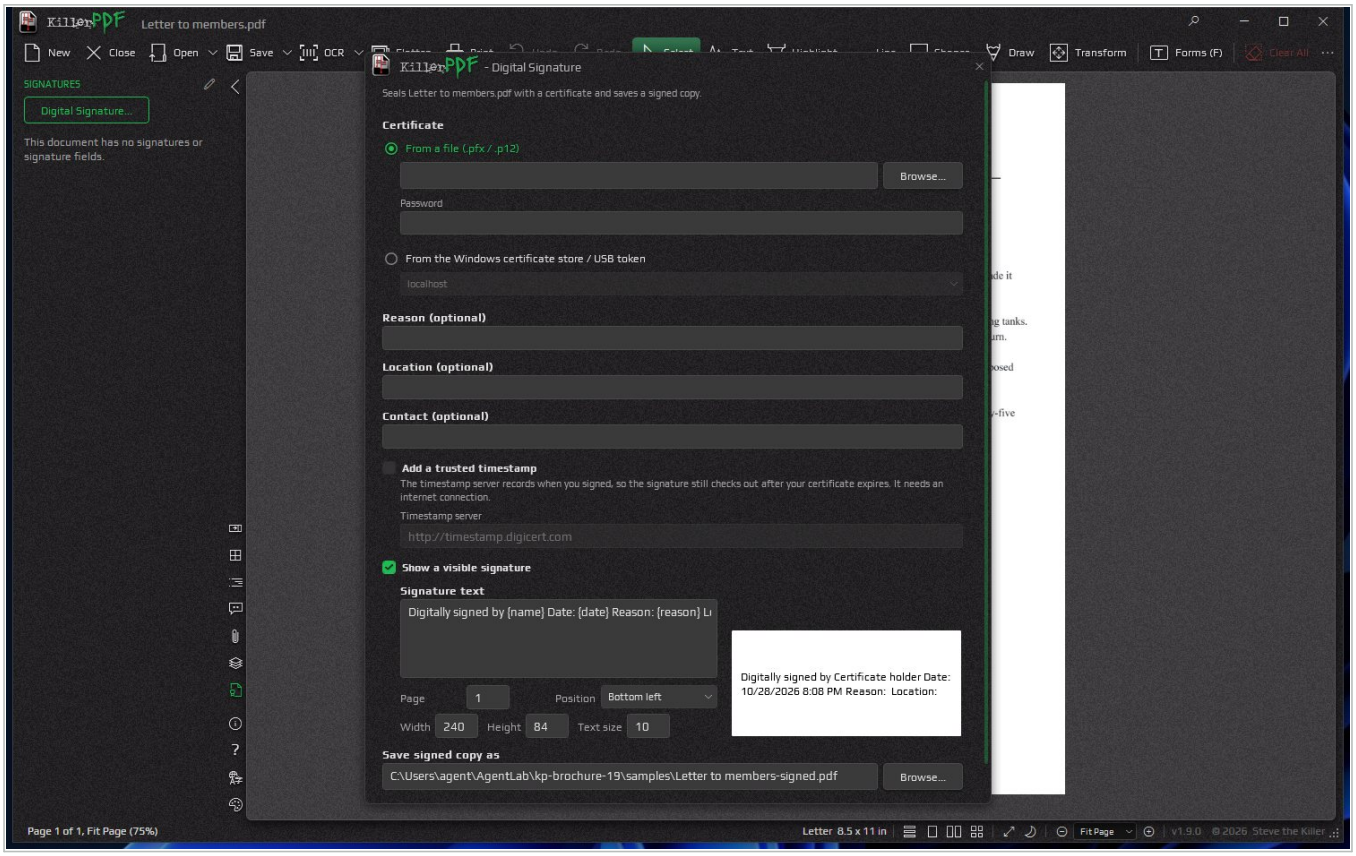
1. Press G or click Signature on the toolbar.
2. Click Create Signature.
3. Draw on the pad with a Thin, Medium or Thick pen, then click Save Signature. Clear starts over.
4. Or click Import Image and pick a png, jpg, jpeg, bmp, gif, tiff, tif or SVG file.
5. For a scan, drag the Sensitivity slider to remove the paper background.
6. Click the page to place it. Drag to move it and use the corner handle to resize it.

Good to know

- Saved signatures and initials are kept for your user and reusable in any document.
- In a form, click a signature field and the saved choice fits into it. Click a signed field to Change or Remove it.
- SVG signatures stay vector.
- A visual signature is drawn into the page on save. It carries no certificate.

Digital signatures

Sign with a certificate so anyone can check who signed and whether the file changed afterward.



The Digital Signature window.

Sign a document

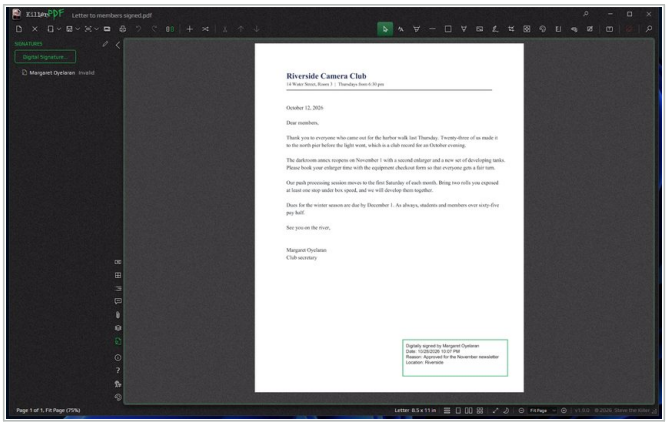
1. Press Ctrl+Shift+G, or open the Signatures panel (Alt+6) and click Digital Signature.
2. Choose a certificate: a .pfx or .p12 file with its password, or one from the Windows certificate store or a USB token.
3. Add a Reason, Location and Contact if you want them.
4. Tick Add a trusted timestamp to use the default server, http://timestamp.digicert.com.
5. Tick Show a visible signature to set its text, page, corner, width, height and text size.
6. Sign. The result is saved as a new copy.

Good to know

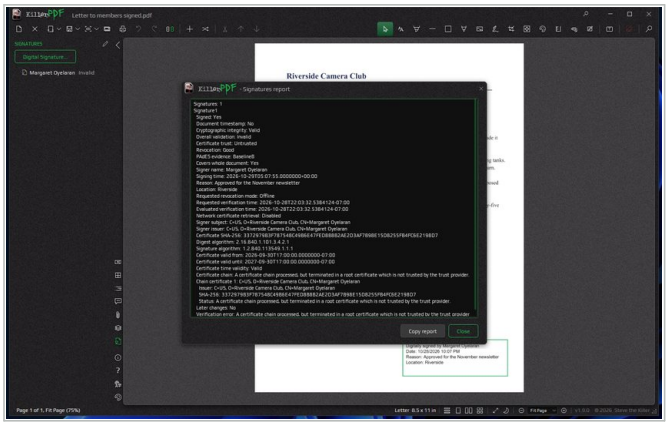
- KillerPDF creates approval signatures only, using SHA-256.
- A timestamp needs an internet connection. If it cannot be obtained, the document is not signed.
- Saving edits to a signed file removes the signature, and KillerPDF warns you first.
- Command line: killerpdf sign in.pdf out.pdf --pfx my.pfx --timestamp

Checking signatures

KillerPDF checks every signature when you open a file and tells you how far it can vouch for it.



The signed club letter with its visible signature and the Signatures panel (Alt+6).



The report for the club letter, signed with a self-signed test certificate: the math checks out, the signer is not trusted.

Signature status

Status	Meaning
Valid	Integrity, trust, certificate dates and revocation all pass.
Invalid	The structure or cryptography fails, the chain is untrusted, the certificate was not yet valid, or it was revoked.
Not fully verified	Nothing failed, but not every check could pass.
Not signed	A signature field with no signature.

Look closer

1. Press Alt+6 to open the Signatures panel.
2. Read each row's status. A row that says changed after signing has later edits.
3. Double-click a row, or press Ctrl+Shift+D then W, for the full report.
4. Press Ctrl+Shift+D then Z to open the Certificates window.

Good to know

- An expired certificate alone does not make a signature Invalid.
- Trust comes from Windows plus roots you mark Trust as Root in KillerPDF. Revocation checks are offline.
- Certificates inside a PDF never become trusted by themselves.
- The Certificates window imports .cer, .crt and .pem files. No private keys.

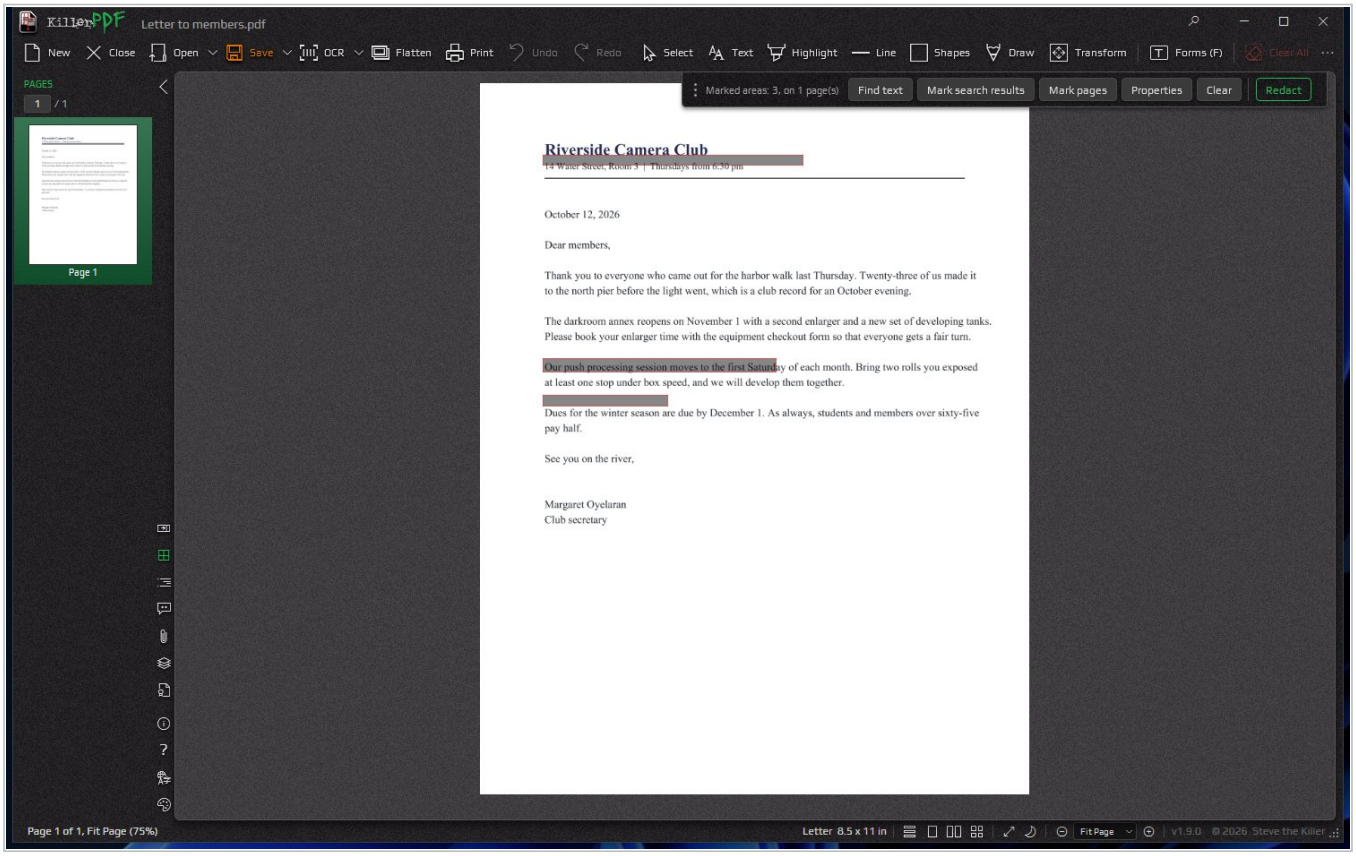
V

Security

- Permanent redaction
- Passwords, permissions and certificates
- Preflight and accessibility reports

Redaction: marking and applying

Redaction permanently removes text, vector art and image pixels under the areas you mark. A black box alone does not.



Redaction marks on the letter.

Mark and redact

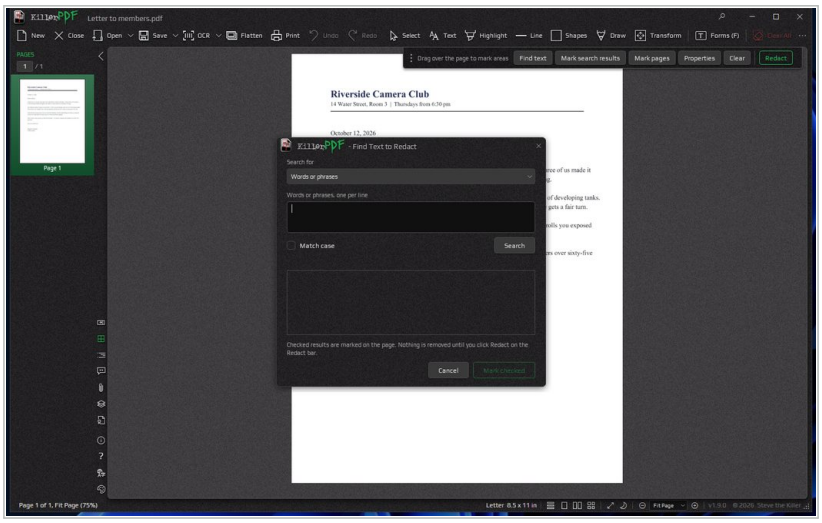
1. Press X or click Redact. The Redact bar appears.
2. Drag over the page to mark areas. The bar counts marked areas and pages.
3. To mark whole pages, click Mark pages and type the pages, such as 1, 3-5.
4. To mark every Ctrl+F match, search first, then use Mark search results.
5. Choose a fill color, a Redaction code or overlay text if you want one.
6. Click Redact.

Good to know

- Marks are only marks until you click Redact. Clear removes them all.
- Marks survive page edits and Undo.
- If content cannot be cleaned on its own, choose Replace page with image, Replace all such pages, or Skip this page.
- Replacing a page with an image removes its old search layer. Text outside the marks stays searchable on pages cleaned without this replacement.

Redaction: search, sanitize, verify

Let KillerPDF find the sensitive text for you, then clean up what else the file carries.



The redaction search window with patterns.

Find and remove

1. In the Redact bar, choose Find text.
2. Pick a Search for option from the table below.
3. For words, type one phrase per line. Tick Match case if needed.
4. Review the results by page. Use Check all or Uncheck all.
5. Click Mark checked. Nothing is removed yet.
6. Click Redact, then pick what else to remove in Finish redaction.

Search for

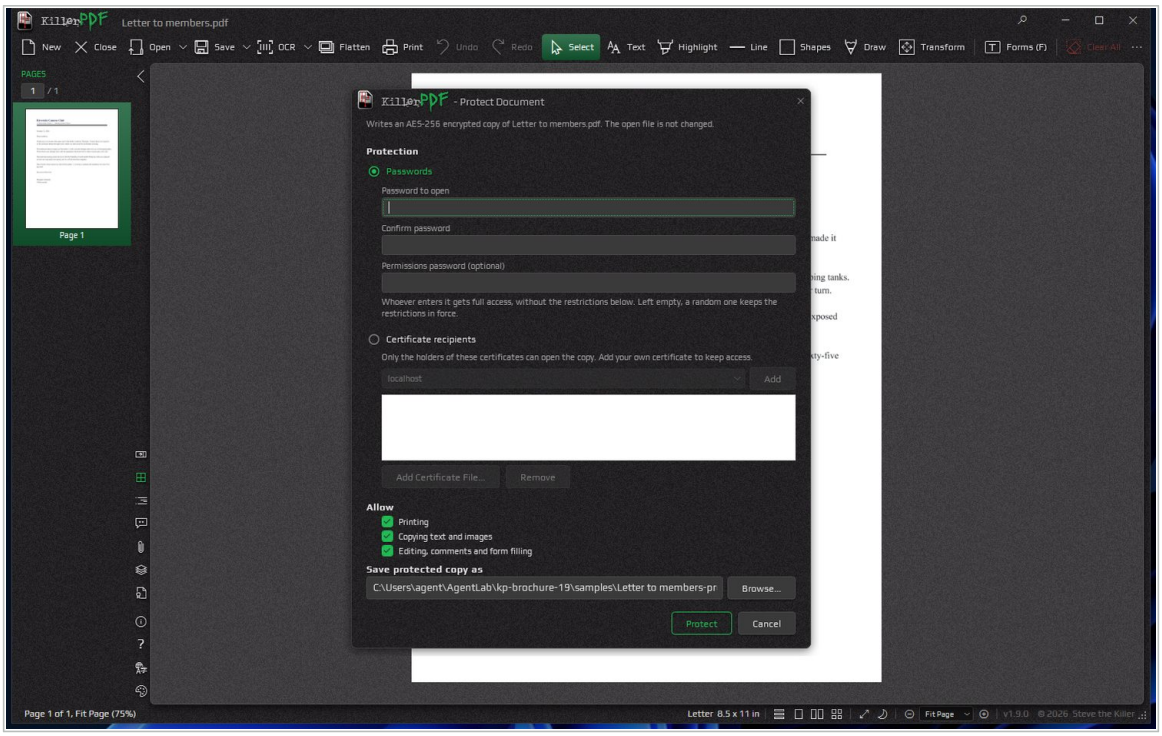
Option	Finds
Words or phrases	Your text
Regular expression	Your pattern
Email addresses	Addresses
Phone numbers	North American numbers
Social Security numbers	ddd-dd-dddd or ddd dd dddd, impossible numbers rejected
Credit card numbers	13 to 19 digits, valid checksum
Bank account numbers (IBAN)	Valid checksum

Sanitize and verify

- Search includes current text edits, form values, annotation text and appearance text such as button captions and stamps.
- Unreadable content is identified. Readable matches do not mean the whole document was searched.
- Finish redaction can remove comments, attached files, form fields, hidden layers, scripts, links and bookmarks. Document info, metadata and thumbnails always go.
- If removal cannot be verified, redaction is refused. Save a new file to keep the original.
- Codes for labels: 14 FOIA exemptions and 10 Privacy Act codes.

Protect with passwords and certificates

Protect Document writes an AES-256 encrypted copy and leaves the open file alone.



The Protect window with passwords and permissions.

Protect a copy

1. Save your document first, including current text and form edits. If saving is canceled or fails, protection does not continue.
2. Press Ctrl+Shift+P, or click the arrow beside Save and choose Protect Document...
3. Choose Passwords or Certificate recipients.
4. For passwords, type a Password to open and confirm it. Add a Permissions password if you want one.
5. For certificates, click Add and pick RSA certificates from the Windows store or a file.
6. Tick what to allow, then save under a different name.

Allow

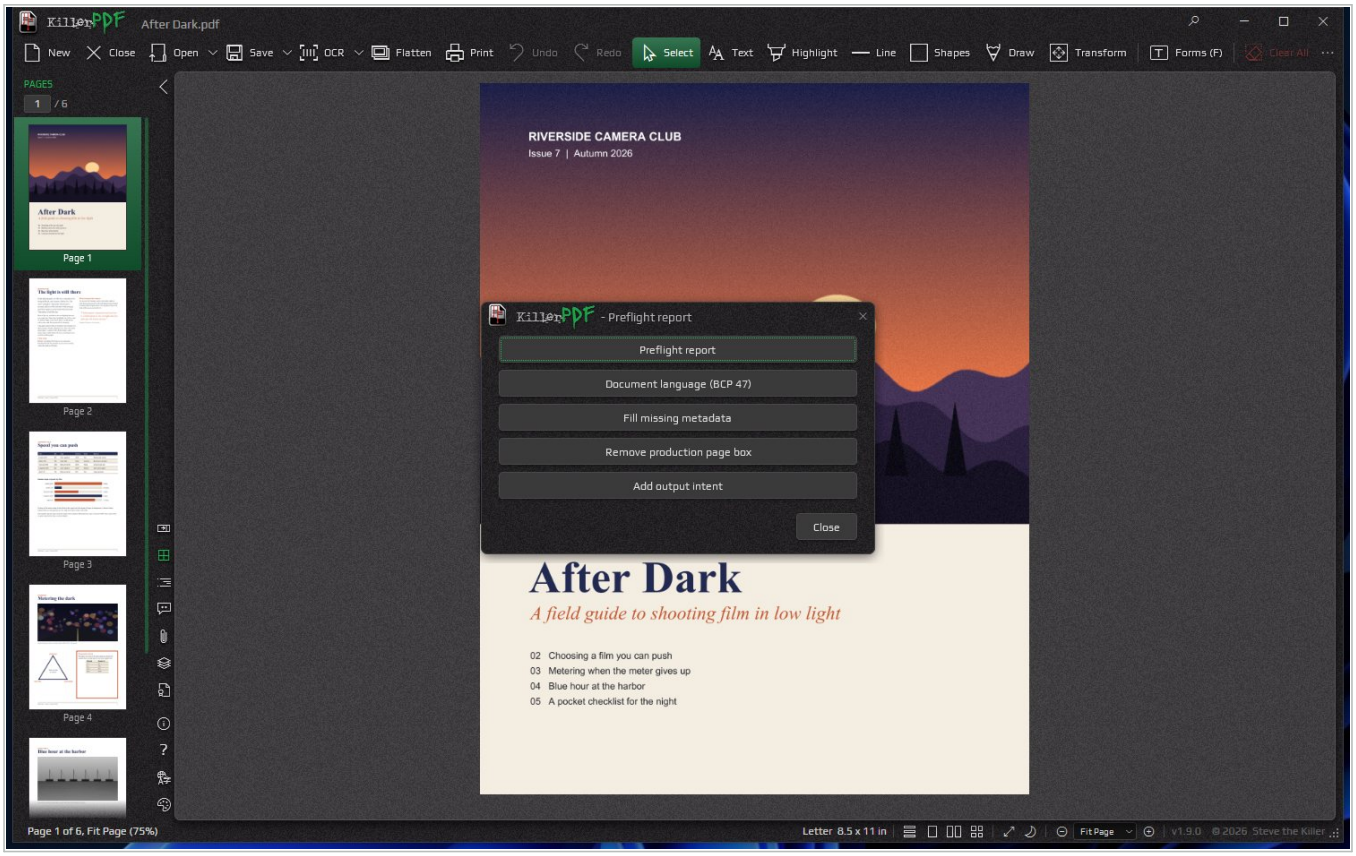
Permission	Covers
Printing	Low and high quality printing
Copying text and images	Copying
Editing, comments and form filling	Edit, annotate, fill, assemble pages

Good to know

- Whoever enters the permissions password gets full access. If you leave it empty, a random 24-byte password keeps restrictions in force.
- Protecting a signed document asks before invalidating its signatures. Decline to keep the signed file unchanged.
- A file with owner restrictions opens read-only. Enter the owner password and click Unlock.
- Remove Password under the Save arrow works when the open file was protected.

Preflight and accessibility reports

Check a file before it goes out. The reports list problems and offer fixes you confirm one at a time.



The preflight report.

Run the checks

1. Press Ctrl+Shift+D, then P, for the Preflight report.
2. Read the findings. Fixes show Before and After and apply only when you confirm.
3. Press Ctrl+Shift+D, then A, for the Accessibility review.
4. Pick a problem and apply a guided repair. The review rechecks, and Undo works.
5. Press Ctrl+Shift+D, then N, for the Navigation audit of links, bookmarks and destinations.
6. Open two documents in split panes and press Ctrl+Shift+D, then C, to compare their structure.

What they check

- Preflight runs ten checks: structure, page boxes, output intent, image resolution, fonts, transparency, color, conformance declarations, layers and metadata. Defaults are 300 dpi and 300% ink.
- Preflight fixes: document language, missing metadata, a production page box, an output intent.
- Accessibility finds missing language, structure, alt text, field and link descriptions, and table headers. It does not prove a file is accessible.
- On the command line, killerpdf preflight takes a profile: general, attachments, print, or your own JSON file.

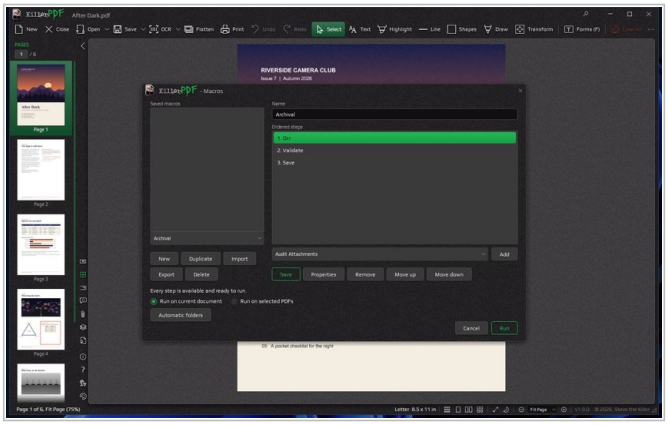
VI

Automation

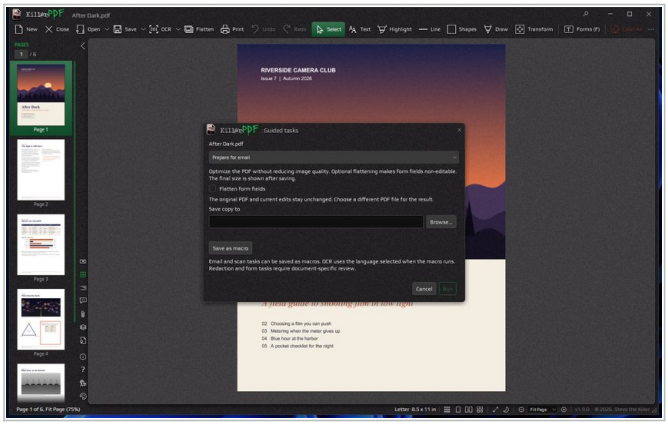
- Macros and Guided Tasks
- Watched folders and batches
- The command line, all 66 commands

Macros and Guided tasks

A macro is a saved list of steps you can run on one PDF or many. Guided tasks walk you through common jobs.



The Macros window.



Guided tasks.

Build a macro

1. Press Ctrl+Shift+D, then M.
2. Create a macro from a starter: Archival, Sharing, Scanning or Privacy.
3. Add, remove and reorder steps, and edit their settings.
4. Click Run on current document, review the preview, and confirm. Or choose Run on selected PDFs.
5. Export a macro as a .json file to share it.

Guided tasks (Ctrl+Shift+D, then X)

Task	What it does
Prepare for email	Optimizes the PDF
Clean up a scan	OCR, then optimize
Remove sensitive information	Review matches and marks
Create a fillable form	Review detected fields

Good to know

- There are 31 step types, among them OCR, Optimize, Redact, Watermark, Flatten, Export, Validate and Save.
- Guided tasks always save a copy and cannot run on signed or read-only PDFs.

Watched folders and batch runs

Automatic folders run a saved macro on every new PDF dropped in a folder. Batch runs do the same for PDFs you pick.

Set up a watched folder

1. Press Alt+Shift+W.
2. Choose an Input folder and a different Output folder.
3. Leave the file name filter at *.pdf or change it.
4. Choose a saved macro.
5. Click Save and start. Use Pause, Resume or Retry failed files as needed.
6. For a one-off batch, open Macros and click Run on selected PDFs.

Limits

Limit	Value
File size	64 MB per PDF
Queued jobs	2,000 files
Subfolders	Not scanned
Passwords or input steps	Need a manual run

Good to know

- It runs while KillerPDF is open, including from the system tray.
- Originals stay. New copies do not keep digital signatures.
- Install OCR models before starting.

The command line

Most of what you can do to a PDF by hand, you can also script. Commands run without opening a window, so they work in batch files, scheduled tasks and other programs.

How it works

Write the command as a bare word, like killerpdf merge, or in the older dashed form, KillerPDF.exe --merge. Both work for all 66 commands. The KillerPDF window can stay open while a command runs. Output goes to the console and the exit code tells a script how it went: 0 means success, 1 means the operation failed, 2 means bad usage or missing input, and 3 means the command ran and reported findings or differences (preflight, accessibility, navigation-audit, compare-structure and auto-bookmarks use it). Reports print JSON when you add --json. To keep passwords out of the command line, add --secrets-stdin and pipe in one JSON object with password, user-password, owner-password or pfx-password. One caveat: scan with --show-settings opens your scanner's own settings window.

Three examples

Command	What it does
killerpdf merge all.pdf a.pdf b.pdf scan.jpg	Joins PDFs and images into one PDF.
killerpdf preflight report.pdf --json	Checks the file and prints findings as JSON. Exits 3 if it finds problems or cannot finish every check.
killerpdf to-image book.pdf pages --dpi 200	Writes each page as a PNG image (150 dpi is the default).

Command reference, part 1

All 66 commands, grouped by purpose. This page covers splitting and combining, page work, OCR and scanning, and security.

Combine and split

Command	What it does
merge	Merges PDFs and images into one PDF.
extract-pages	Pulls pages, such as 1-3,5,9-12, into a new PDF.
split	Writes one PDF per page, or by --every, --parts, --bookmarks or --max-size.

Pages

Command	What it does
rotate-pages	Rotates selected pages by 90, 180 or 270 degrees.
delete-pages	Removes selected pages.
move-pages	Moves pages before a one-based position.
insert-blank	Inserts a blank page before a one-based position.
duplicate-page	Duplicates one page.
reverse-pages	Reverses the order of all or selected pages.
fix-orientation	Turns pages upright, using OCR to read scans.
straighten	Levels tilted scans that have no text layer.
divide-spreads	Splits two-page spreads into single pages.
rasterize-region	Turns one box on a page into an image.

OCR and scanning

Command	What it does
ocr	Adds an invisible, searchable text layer. Other languages download on first use.
scan-to-text	Turns scanned pages into real text in a matching typeface.
scan	Scans through a TWAIN scanner into a PDF. --list shows scanners.

Security and signing

Command	What it does
redact	Permanently removes content, by phrase, pattern, list or whole page. --dry-run previews.
protect	Saves an AES-256 copy with passwords, permissions or certificate recipients.
decrypt	Removes encryption, losslessly when possible.
sign	Adds a digital signature, optionally timestamped and visible.

Command reference, part 2

This page covers conversion, export and forms, plus the reports and audits that read a file without changing it.

Conversion, export and forms

Command	What it does
to-image	Renders pages to PNG or JPEG images.
flatten	Rasterizes into an uneditable PDF, optionally with a scanned look.
export	Exports to .docx, .xlsx, .pptx, .html, .md, .txt or .json.
convert-office	Converts a Word or Excel file to PDF.
replace-text	Rewrites matching lines in their own fonts.
data-merge	Fills one copy of a form per record from CSV, JSON or XLSX.
export-form-data	Writes form data to .fdf, .xfdf or .json.
import-form-data	Fills a form from .fdf or .xfdf data.
recognize-fields	Finds form fields, and can add text fields and check boxes.
xfa-to-acroform	Converts an XFA form to standard fields.
flatten-forms	Turns form fields into page content.
macro	Runs a saved macro, a macro file or a starter. macro --list shows saved ones.

Reports and audits

Command	What it does
preflight	Checks a file against a profile. Exits 3 when it finds problems or cannot finish every check.
accessibility	Reports accessibility findings. Exits 3 when it finds any.
document-info	Prints document details as JSON.
search-text	Prints page hits for a query as JSON.
signatures	Lists each signature's signer, time, trust and later changes.
comments	Lists review comments and their replies.
measurements	Reports saved measurements as JSON or CSV.
layers	Lists layers with their visibility and locks.
portfolio	Shows portfolio presentation, fields and folders.
attachments	Lists embedded files, or extracts them to a folder.
compare-structure	Compares content, resources and geometry. Exits 3 when they differ.
navigation-audit	Checks links, bookmarks and destinations. Exits 3 when it finds problems.

Command reference, part 3

This page covers structure and navigation, print and production, and the commands for installation checks and test runs.

Structure and navigation

Command	What it does
number-pages	Stamps page numbers, with a template, edge, alignment and number format.
auto-bookmarks	Builds an outline from detected headings. Exits 3 if it finds none.
toc	Inserts clickable contents pages built from the bookmarks.
page-labels	Sets page-label ranges, such as 1:lower-roman,5:decimal.
initial-view	Sets the page, zoom, layout and window options a viewer opens with.
repair-links	Removes unsafe or broken links.
set-layer	Renames a layer, or sets its visibility and lock.
portfolio-view	Sets a portfolio to details, tile or hidden view, or clears it.
add-attachment	Embeds one or more files in the PDF.
edit-attachment	Renames, describes, retypes or removes an embedded file.

Print and production

Command	What it does
print	Prints silently to a named printer, or the default one.
print-production	Reports page boxes, inks and output intents.
separations	Lists inks, or writes each page's plates as images.
bates	Stamps one continuous Bates sequence across several files.
booklet	Lays out two-up saddle-stitch imposition.
nup	Places several pages on each sheet.
optimize	Reduces file size by stripping parts and resampling images.

Installation and harnesses

Command	What it does
help	Prints the usage text.
version	Prints the version.
verify	Verifies every installed payload file.
batch-resave	Resaves a file or folder tree and logs each result. Used for validation runs.
batch-render	Renders the first pages of a file or tree to PNG with per-page timings.

VII

The engine

- The KillerPDF.Engine
- Standards, limits and honesty
- Corpus results and components

ENGINE

The KillerPDF.Engine

The engine is the library underneath KillerPDF 1.9. It has no user interface, so the same code can run in the app, on the command line and in your own programs.

What it is

It is a .NET 10 library, package id KillerPdf.Engine, licensed GPL-3.0-only. It targets plain net10.0, and its source calls no Windows APIs. I have not tested it on Linux or macOS, so I will not promise it. In 1.9 it replaces PDFium, PdfPig and Docnet.Core for rendering, text extraction, search, editing, printing and export.

What it can do

Area	Capabilities
Reading and recovery	Parses classic and stream cross-references, object streams and incremental revisions, and recovers damaged files in bounded ways. Extracts words, fonts, images and paths.
Rendering	Draws pages on the CPU, including transparency, shadings, ICC color, overprint, annotations and form appearances. Decodes JPEG, JPEG 2000, JBIG2, CCITT, Flate and more.
Writing and editing	Writes deterministic full rewrites or byte-preserving incremental updates. Inserts, reorders, rotates and crops pages. Optimizes and exports.
Forms and annotations	Authors and edits AcroForm fields, reads FDF, XFDF and XFA, merges data, and handles comments, markup and measurements.
Security and signing	Password and certificate encryption, signature creation, timestamps and verification, and content redaction.
Text and OCR	Text extraction, plus its own OCR with downloadable language models.

Standards and security

Here is what the engine does with PDF standards, and where it stops.

Topic	What the engine does
PDF versions	Reads PDF 1.x and 2.0. Authors PDF 2.0.
Validates	Checks PDF/A-4 and PDF/UA-2 declarations on existing files. Other declared PDF/A or PDF/UA parts produce unsupported findings.
Authors	PDF/A-4, PDF/A-4e, PDF/A-4f and PDF/UA-2, with safeguards that refuse output that breaks their rules.
Encryption	Opens and rewrites files protected with RC4, AES-128 or AES-256 passwords, and keeps the original encryption when it saves them. New files use AES-256, revision 6 by default, or revision 7 with AES-GCM on PDF 2.0. Certificate recipients are supported.
Signatures	Writes detached CMS signatures as incremental revisions, with RFC 3161 timestamps from a timestamp server. Verifies integrity, coverage and later changes.
Trust	Opt-in. Expired, untrusted and invalid stay separate, and embedded certificates never become trust anchors.

Limits

- The checks are not full PDF/A or PDF/UA validators, and PDF/X gets boundary checks only.
- The engine does not author document timestamps.
- PAdES evidence is classified, and DSS data can be written when the host supplies the evidence. It does not fetch revocation data or complete long-term validation itself.
- Rewriting or encrypting a signed document is refused unless you allow signature invalidation. Adding another signature is an incremental update that keeps the earlier ones, unless a certification signature forbids it.

Proof: corpus and tests

I test against a large set of real and hostile PDFs. Each number below says what it was measured on and when.

Number	What it is
47,024	Inputs in the corpus: 46,944 in three normal collections plus 80 damaged files. The same set was used for 1.8.90 and for the 1.9.0 corpus runs of October 2026.
109 more, none lost	Saves by 1.9.0 compared with 1.8.90, published in the 1.9.0 corpus report (follow-up run, 2026-10-15).
38 to 57 percent	Lower peak memory in that same run: standards and color 37.97, private stress 49.37, public regression 56.85.
7,443	Engine tests on the 1.9.0 development build, all passing on October 28, 2026.
1,451	App tests on the 1.9.0 development build that open no window, all passing on October 28, 2026.

Limits

- The corpora are hostile, so some files still fail to save, and every normal batch exits 1 because of it.
- In the 2026-10-15 run, regression time was 1.74 percent longer (inside session noise). Standards and stress were 9.53 and 7.62 percent shorter.
- That run measures opening and saving, not rendering accuracy or PDF conformance.

Components and fonts

These are the main third-party components in the KillerPDF 1.9 build, with their licenses. The full texts are in the notices file.

Component	License
ONNX Runtime 1.29.0	MIT
CoreJ2K 2.4.1 (JPEG 2000, vendored)	BSD-3-Clause
JBIG2 decoder, modified from Apache PDFBox	Apache-2.0
Tesseract 5.2.0 (OCR fallback)	Apache-2.0
Leptonica 1.82.0	Leptonica license
SixLabors.Fonts 1.0.0-beta17	Apache-2.0
NTwain 3.7.6 (scanning, vendored)	MIT
CommunityToolkit.Mvvm 8.4.2	MIT
Liberation Fonts 2.1.5	SIL OFL 1.1
Killer Sans, Killer Sans UI, Lacquer	SIL OFL 1.1
Punktype (logo)	Commercial license held by the author

PDFium, PdfPig, Docnet.Core and PdfSharp are no longer used. Two small pieces of PDFium-derived data remain, under its BSD-style license: Symbol and ZapfDingbats font outlines, and a CMYK conversion table.

VIII

Reference

- Every keyboard shortcut
- Languages
- Install, update and integrations

Keyboard shortcuts: file, tools and editing

Press F1 in the app to see the full list and a keyboard map. Bare-letter tool keys pause while you type in a text or form field.

File

Keys	Action
Ctrl+O	Open
Ctrl+S	Save
Ctrl+Shift+S	Save As
Ctrl+W	Close file
Ctrl+Shift+W	Close other tabs
Ctrl+Shift+Q	Close all
Ctrl+Q	Quit
Ctrl+N	New blank document
Ctrl+P	Print
Ctrl+D or F4	Document info
Shift+F4	Show current file size
Ctrl+Shift+E	Export Document
Ctrl+Shift+P	Protect Document
Alt+Shift+T	Export table
Alt+Shift+E	Export Pages as Images
Alt+Shift+Z	Reduce File Size
Alt+Shift+C	Compress to ZIP
Alt+Shift+F	Flatten
Alt+Shift+B	Merge PDFs
Alt+Shift+X	Extract Page(s)

Tools

Keys	Action
V	Select
T	Text
H	Highlight
L or U	Line
O	Shapes
Shift+O	Next shape type
D	Draw
I	Add Image
G	Signature
C	Crop
R	Transform
Ctrl+R	Rotate Page CW
Ctrl+Shift+R	Rotate Page CCW
S	Stamp Pages
F	Fillable text field
E	Color Correction
M	Measure
Shift+M	Next measurement type
X	Redact
Alt+Shift+1	Distance
Alt+Shift+2	Perimeter
Alt+Shift+3	Area
Alt+Shift+4	Angle
Alt+Shift+5	Set the drawing scale for this page

Editing

Keys	Action
Alt+Shift+P	Edit paragraph
Ctrl+Z	Undo
Ctrl+Y or Ctrl+Shift+Z	Redo
Ctrl+C	Copy selected text
Ctrl+V	Paste image or text
Ctrl+B, Ctrl+I, Ctrl+U	Bold, italic, underline in a text box
Delete	Delete selected annotation
F2	Rename
Ctrl+Enter	Commit a text box (Enter starts a new line)
Enter	Confirm a crop
Esc	Cancel a text or crop edit
Menu or Shift+F10	Context menu at selection

Keyboard shortcuts: view and navigation

Views, navigation, panels, search, OCR and help. Customize Shortcuts in the F1 card lets you remap keys, and Ctrl+Shift+K turns shortcuts on and off.

View

Keys	Action
F5	Continuous
F6	Single Page
F7	Two Page
B	Book layout
F8	Grid
F10	Split pane
F11 or Esc	Full screen
Alt+M	Hide toolbar
N	Invert document colors
Shift+N	Invert images too
Ctrl+Shift++, Ctrl+Shift+-, Ctrl+Shift+0	Zoom the whole app
Wheel on logo	Zoom the whole app
Alt+Shift+G	Film Grain
Alt+Shift+N	Show page navigation buttons
Ctrl+Shift+1 to 6	Toolbar appearance
Alt+Shift+Up	Tabs on top
Alt+Shift+Down	Tabs on bottom

Navigation

Keys	Action
Left, Right, PgUp, PgDn	Previous or next page
Home, End	First or last page
Alt+Left, Alt+Right	Back or forward in jump history
Up, Down	Scroll, flipping the page at the edges
Ctrl+Scroll	Zoom in or out around the cursor
Ctrl++, Ctrl+-	Zoom in or out
Ctrl+0	Reset zoom to 100 percent
Ctrl+1, Ctrl+2, Ctrl+3	Actual size, fit width, fit page
Middle drag	Pan view
Space + drag	Pan view
F9	Toggle sidebar
Shift+F9	Move sidebar to the next side
Ctrl+Tab	Next tab
Ctrl+Shift+Tab	Previous tab
Ctrl+Shift+N	Move to New Window

Panels

Keys	Action
Alt+1	Pages
Alt+2	Outline
Alt+3	Comments and measurements
Alt+4	Attachments
Alt+5	Layers
Alt+6	Signatures

Search and select

Keys	Action
Ctrl+K	Search Tools
Ctrl+F	Find Text
Ctrl+H	Find and replace
F3 or Enter	Next result
Shift+F3 or Shift+Enter	Previous result
Ctrl+A	Select all text on page
Shift+Click	Add to selection

OCR and help

Keys	Action
Ctrl+Shift+O	OCR Page (Copy Text)
Ctrl+Shift+I	OCR Region
Ctrl+Shift+T	Convert Scan to Text
F1 or Ctrl+?	This shortcut list
F12	About dialog
Ctrl+Shift+K	Toggle keyboard shortcuts

Keyboard shortcuts: document tools

Press Ctrl+Shift+D to open the Document tools menu, then press the letter beside a tool to run it. A few document tools also have their own direct keys.

Direct keys

Keys	Action
Ctrl+Shift+D	Document tools menu
Ctrl+Shift+G	Digital Signature
Alt+Shift+V	Compare PDFs
Alt+Shift+W	Automatic folders
Alt+Shift+A	Add Blank Page
Alt+Shift+R	Reverse Page Order
Alt+Shift+O	Fix Page Orientation
Alt+Shift+S	Straighten Scanned Pages
Alt+Shift+D	Divide Spreads
Alt+Shift+L	Rasterize Region

Document tools chord: press Ctrl+Shift+D, then the letter

Keys	Action
Ctrl+Shift+D, P	Preflight report
Ctrl+Shift+D, R	Print production report
Ctrl+Shift+D, S	Separation preview report
Ctrl+Shift+D, A	Accessibility review
Ctrl+Shift+D, W	Signatures report
Ctrl+Shift+D, Z	Certificates
Ctrl+Shift+D, L	Layers report
Ctrl+Shift+D, E	Edit layers
Ctrl+Shift+D, F	Portfolio report
Ctrl+Shift+D, O	Edit portfolio
Ctrl+Shift+D, U	Edit portfolio structure
Ctrl+Shift+D, T	Edit attachments
Ctrl+Shift+D, K	Comments
Ctrl+Shift+D, Y	Measurements
Ctrl+Shift+D, N	Navigation audit
Ctrl+Shift+D, B	Create bookmarks from headings
Ctrl+Shift+D, G	Edit page labels
Ctrl+Shift+D, V	Initial view settings
Ctrl+Shift+D, C	Structural comparison report
Ctrl+Shift+D, X	Guided tasks
Ctrl+Shift+D, M	Macros
Ctrl+Shift+D, D	Data merge
Ctrl+Shift+D, I	Insert table of contents
Ctrl+Shift+D, H	Form data
Ctrl+Shift+D, J	Bookmark data
Ctrl+Shift+D, Q	Production layouts and Bates batches

Interface languages

KillerPDF's interface comes in 20 languages. Dates and numbers keep your Windows regional format whatever language you pick.

The 20 languages

Language	Shown in the menu as	Code
English	English	en-US
Bengali	বাংলা	bn
Czech	Čeština	cs-CZ
German	Deutsch	de-DE
Spanish	Español	es
French	Français	fr-FR
Hungarian	Magyar	hu-HU
Italian	Italiano	it-IT
Japanese	日本語	ja-JP
Kazakh	Қазақша	kk-KZ
Norwegian Bokmål	Norsk bokmål	nb-NO
Polish	Polski	pl-PL
Portuguese (Brazil)	Português (Brasil)	pt-BR
Russian	Русский	ru-RU
Slovenian	Slovenščina	sl-SI
Turkish	Türkçe	tr-TR
Ukrainian	Українська	uk-UA
Vietnamese	Tiếng Việt	vi-VN
Chinese (Simplified)	中文 (简体)	zh-CN
Chinese (Traditional)	中文 (繁體)	zh-TW

Switching

- Click the Language button on the sidebar rail and pick a language. The interface changes at once.
- On first run KillerPDF follows your Windows display language, or English if it has no match.
- Any text a language file lacks falls back to English. Slovenian is new in 1.9.

REFERENCE

Install, update and requirements

KillerPDF comes as an installer, a portable file and a Store package. The app never needs administrator rights; only a machine-wide install asks for them.

Ways to get it

Option	Details
Installer	KillerPDF.exe. Choose Install for my account or Install for everyone on this computer. Needs the x64 .NET 10 Desktop Runtime.
Portable	KillerPDF-Portable.exe. One file, no install, runtime included. Data sits in a KillerPDF-Data folder beside it.
Microsoft Store	A package with the runtime included.
WinGet	Package id SteveTheKiller.KillerPDF (winget install SteveTheKiller.KillerPDF)
Chocolatey	Package id killerpdf

Updates, files and requirements

- On startup KillerPDF checks GitHub for a newer release (on by default) and asks before installing. It checks the file's checksum and its publisher signature first.
- KillerPDF adds itself to the Open with list for .pdf files without changing your default PDF app, and a file you launch from the same Windows session opens in the running copy as a new tab.
- Requires 64-bit Windows. The installer edition needs the x64 .NET 10 Desktop Runtime; the Portable and Store editions include it.

REFERENCE

KillerMCP and KillerNotes

KillerPDF works with AI agents through KillerMCP, a separate project. The integration lives in KillerMCP, not in the KillerPDF app. You reach the note tools by asking your AI agent, since KillerPDF itself has no menu item for saving to KillerNotes.

KillerMCP

KillerMCP drives your installed KillerPDF through its command line. It registers with Codex, Claude Code, Claude Desktop, Cursor, GitHub Copilot, Gemini CLI and Windsurf when it finds them. Each source PDF can be up to 64 MiB. Merge takes 2 to 8 PDFs, up to 128 MiB combined. Tools that make files need a new output path and refuse to overwrite.

Save as note, when KillerNotes is also installed

Tool	What it does
killerpdf_save_text_as_note	Exports a PDF's text as Markdown and saves it as one new note.
killerpdf_save_report_as_note	Runs a report (signatures, comments, measurements or preflight findings) and saves it as a note. It never changes the PDF.
killerpdf_save_pages_as_notes	Renders selected pages and saves each page image as a new note.

KillerPDF

Colophon

DESIGN AND DEVELOPMENT

KillerPDF and this guide are designed and built by Steve the Killer.

LICENSE

KillerPDF and the KillerPDF.Engine are free software under the GPL-3.0.

TYPE

Titles in Killer Sans. The wordmark sets "Killer" in Punktype by junkohanhero and "PDF" in Lacquer. Body text in Helvetica.

SCREENSHOTS

Every screenshot is KillerPDF 1.9 running on Windows 11 at 100 percent scaling.

SAMPLE DOCUMENTS

The camera club guide, form and letter in the screenshots were written for this guide. Their photos are generated, not borrowed.

THIS FILE

Made with ReportLab from source facts checked against the KillerPDF code. Open it in KillerPDF and use the bookmarks to jump around.